



Working With Reports In Google Analytics 4

Created by



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We're still scratching the surface here

I want to set the right expectations.

Even though I tried to write a comprehensive e-book here, there are many more things you must learn to call yourself a Google Analytics 4 expert and unlock its potential.

Remember: it's not just about the reports. It's about deciding what's important to track, asking the right questions and then answer them with the data. This e-book focuses only on the interface, how to navigate it and how to build reports (not how to identify KPIs, how to ask the right questions or how to analyze the data).

If you are looking for the fastest way to learn that (+ support), then 🙌 🙌 🙌



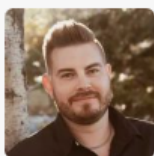
I can help you learn GA4

Hi, my name is Julius. I founded Analytics Mania in late 2016. Since then, the blog has grown to hundreds of thousands of monthly visits. Here I share my knowledge, experiments, and learnings related to web analytics, mainly Google Tag Manager (GTM) & Google Analytics 4 (GA4).

I actively help others to learn Google Analytics 4 with blog, videos, and online courses. In my [Google Analytics 4 course](#), you will learn the following:

- How to **plan** your setup
- How to define what is essential to measure KPIs
- How to properly **configure** Google Analytics 4
- How to build **reports**
- How to **get insights** from your data

You can [learn more about my Google Analytics 4 course here](#).



"I have been reading Analytics Mania blog posts for the past 3 years, and they have helped me better understand GA4 and GTM. I knew that if I purchased the course, it would further my understanding, but within the first couple of modules, I was already blown away.

– **Andrew Ross**, Data Operations Specialist at LotLinX, Inc.



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Part I

Standard reports



IMPORTANT. READ THIS FIRST.

Google Analytics 4 is under heavy development. It means that every month you will get some new features (and sometimes, the current ones change). Current features might be renamed, moved to a different part of the interface. That is just how GA works right now.

So if you notice some differences between this e-book and what you see in the interface, don't panic. Just keep looking and you will eventually find it.

To benefit from this e-book, you must have Google Analytics 4 installed on your website, and it should already have some data collected.

#1.1 Overview of Standard Reports

Standard reports in Google Analytics 4 (GA4) are your starting point for analyzing key website performance metrics. These reports are pre-built and designed to give you a snapshot of your users' behavior, engagement, and conversions.

GA4 organizes these insights into several categories, helping you quickly understand how people are finding your website, interacting with content, and whether they're completing desired actions.

The list of standard reports depends on what checkboxes did you pick while creating a Google Analytics 4 property (see on the right) →.

Personally, I prefer selecting the “Other” reports (also known as baseline reports). In addition to “Reports snapshot”, “Realtime overview”, “Realtime pages”, you will get the standard collection of the following report groups:

Choose your business objectives

For reports that are personalized to your business, select the topics most important to you.

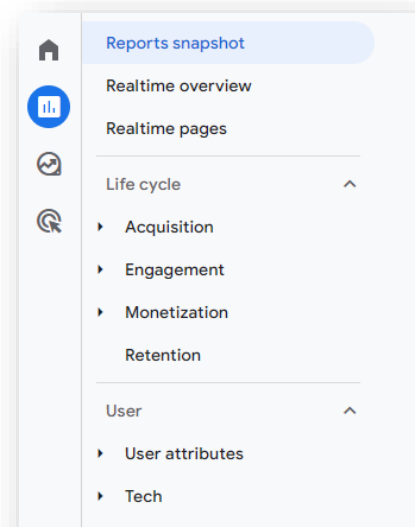
- ☐ **Leads**
Track actions that identify visitors as potential customers
- ☐ **Sales**
Analyze and optimize sales on your website or app
- ☐ **Traffic**
Measure who is visiting your website or app and where they are coming from
- ☐ **User engagement & retention**
Learn how people explore your products or services
- ☐ **Other**
Multiple types of reports (this option can't be combined with other options)

- Acquisition
- Engagement
- Monetization
- Retention
- User reports

At the core of GA4's reporting are the lifecycle and user-centric reports. Lifecycle reports focus on user interactions at different stages, from how they first arrive on your site to how they engage, convert, and return over time. On the other hand, user reports give you a detailed breakdown of who these users are—providing insights into demographics, devices, and geographic location.

For users with basic needs, these standard reports might meet most of their analysis requirements. They cover the essential metrics businesses rely on, including traffic acquisition, user engagement, and retention.

Each report is easily accessible from the navigation menu, making it a practical solution for users who need to look at their data right away. They can also be customized (to some extent), but more on that – later.



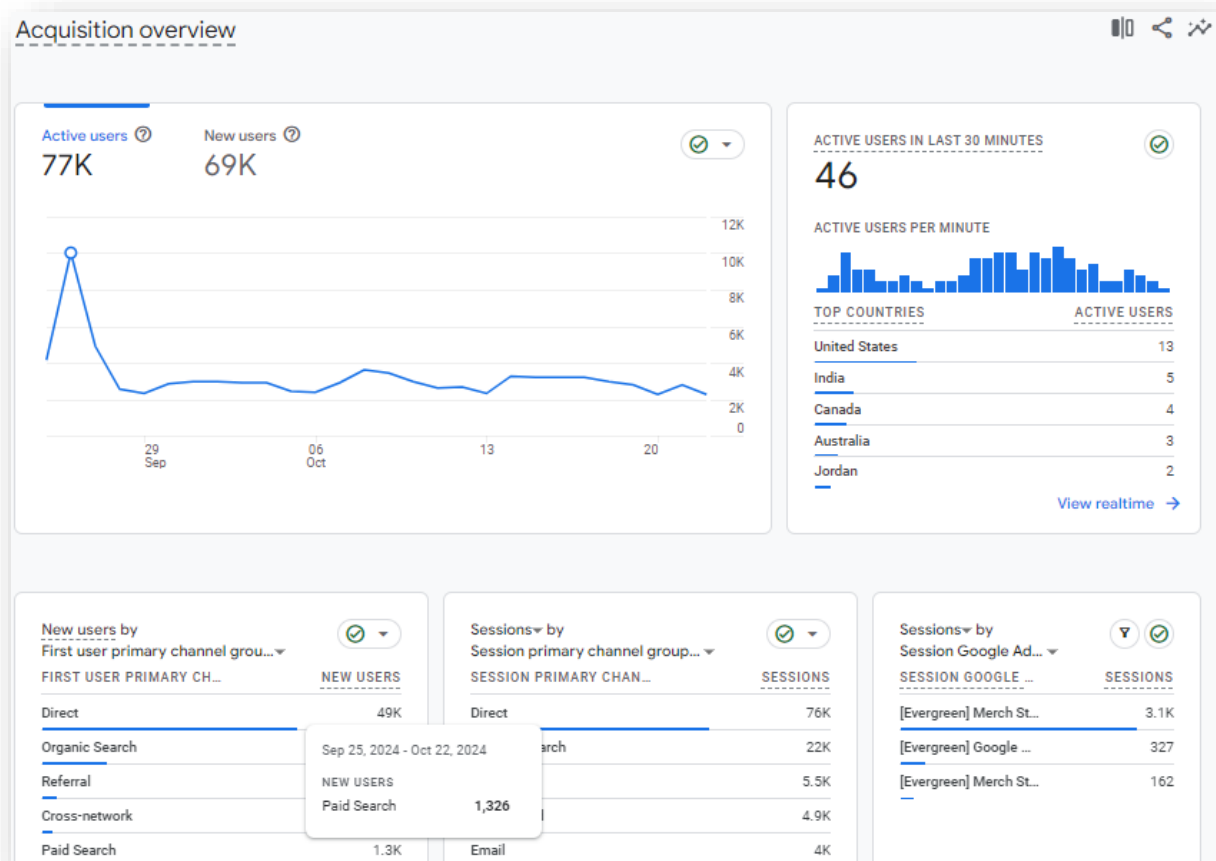
#1.2 Types of reports

Google Analytics 4 organizes its standard reports into two primary formats: **Overview reports** and **Detail reports**. Each serves a distinct purpose in presenting your data.

#1.2.1. Overview reports

Overview reports are designed to give you a high-level summary of key metrics and trends. Instead of diving deep into specific data points, these reports use cards or widgets to visually represent the most important metrics for quick consumption. Each card provides a snapshot of data, such as user acquisition or engagement.

For example, the **acquisition overview** report will display cards showing how many new users your website has attracted, where they came from (e.g., organic search, social media), etc.



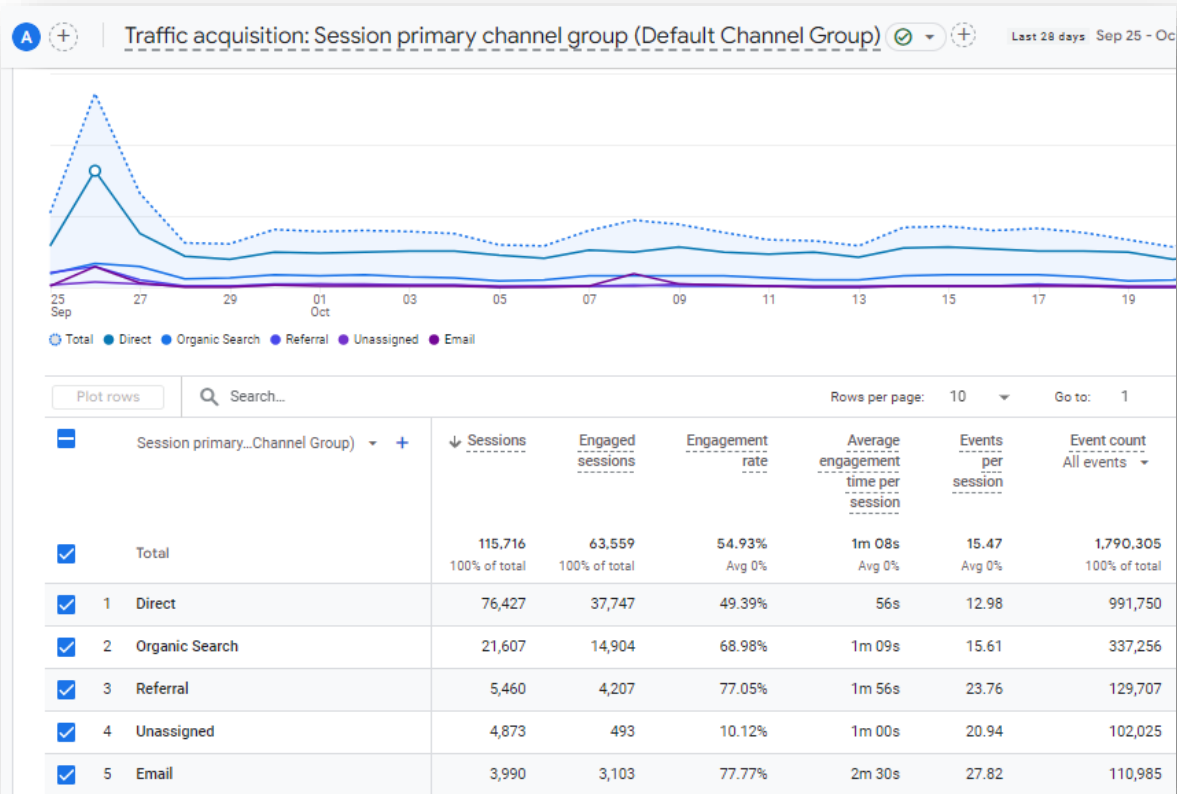
Some users might find them useful when they need a fast way to see the overall website performance. However, I rarely use them. Instead, I prefer the detail reports.

#1.2.2. Detail reports

Detail reports, on the other hand, are where you can find more granular data. These reports feature tables with customizable columns, dimensions, and metrics, allowing you to analyze specific aspects of user behavior and site performance in greater detail.

Optionally, you can also add one or more charts. The tables typically show data like the number of users, sessions, events, and conversions for specific dimensions such as traffic source, location, or device.

For instance, if you're looking at the **Traffic Acquisition** report, you'll see a table that breaks down users by traffic source (e.g., Google, direct, referral), along with metrics like sessions, key event, session key event rate, etc. You can sort, filter, and even drill down (to some extent) into the data to explore how different channels are driving traffic and conversions (key events).

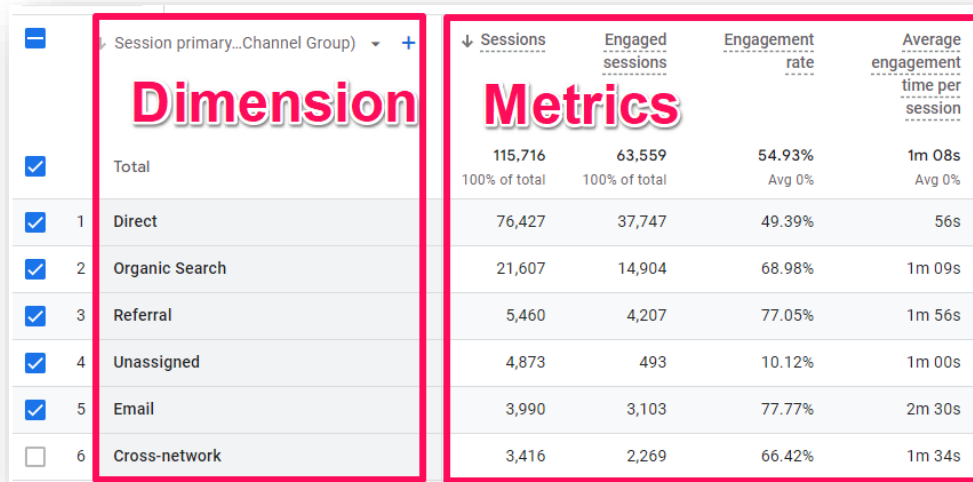


#1.3 Using detail reports

Let's take a closer look at detail reports (especially tables) since you will be spending a lot of time here.

Each table consists of two main parts:

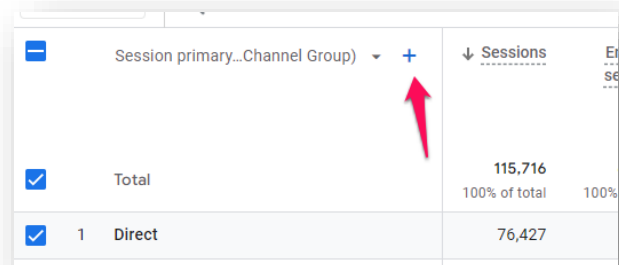
1. **Dimensions** (attributes that describe your data, e.g., name of a country, traffic source, visitor age, etc.)
2. **Metrics** (numbers that show how well/poor each dimension is performing. E.g., number of sessions, engagement rate, etc.)



The screenshot shows a table with two main sections: 'Dimension' and 'Metrics'. The 'Dimension' section lists channel groups, and the 'Metrics' section shows sessions, engaged sessions, engagement rate, and average engagement time per session.

	Dimension	Sessions	Engaged sessions	Engagement rate	Average engagement time per session
	Total	115,716 100% of total	63,559 100% of total	54.93% Avg 0%	1m 08s Avg 0%
1	Direct	76,427	37,747	49.39%	56s
2	Organic Search	21,607	14,904	68.98%	1m 09s
3	Referral	5,460	4,207	77.05%	1m 56s
4	Unassigned	4,873	493	10.12%	1m 00s
5	Email	3,990	3,103	77.77%	2m 30s
6	Cross-network	3,416	2,269	66.42%	1m 34s

By default, a report has one dimension. But you can add one more. It's called "Secondary dimension". You can do this by clicking the Plus icon in the dimension column and then picking a dimension.



The screenshot shows a table with a plus icon in the dimension column, indicating the addition of a secondary dimension. The table shows the total sessions and the sessions for the 'Direct' channel group.

	Dimension	Sessions
	Total	115,716 100% of total
1	Direct	76,427

A useful example could be to add "Session source / medium" to the report that shows "Session primary channel group" as the primary dimension.

↓ Session primary...Channel Group) ▾		Session source / medium ▾ ×
Total		
1	Referral	9to5google.com / referral
2	Referral	adclick.g.doubleclick.net / referral
3	Referral	androidheadlines.com / referral
4	Referral	art-analytics.appspot.com / referral
5	Referral	cac-word-edit.officeapps.live.com / referral

At the top-left corner of the table, you will find the search field, which lets you filter down the reports a bit. Enter a particular word/phrase, and GA4 will show you the rows where the dimension(s) contains that text.

You can use this only for basic purposes. Unfortunately, when I am writing this e-book, more complex filtering (e.g., include rows where a metric is greater than X) is not possible.

Next to the search field, there's also a **Plot rows** feature that lets you control the output of the chart above the table. You can learn more about the feature [here](#).

Some metric columns have dropdowns that let you select a particular event (or [key event](#)).

For example, instead of all Key Events (previously known as Conversions), you can select just the purchase event (if you have implemented GA4 ecommerce tracking, of course).

This simple modification in the Traffic Acquisition report will show you which traffic sources generate the most purchases.

↓ Session primary...Channel Group) +		Key events purchase ▾	Session key event rate purchase ▾	Total revenue
☐	Total	2,066.00 1.37% of total	1.73% Avg 0%	\$311,534.43 100% of total
☐	1 Unassigned	97.00	1.87%	\$6,829.58
☐	2 Referral	258.00	4.58%	\$31,284.71
☐	3 Paid Search	29.00	1.11%	\$10,873.94
☐	4 Paid Other	0.00	0%	\$0.00
☐	5 Organic Video	0.00	0%	\$0.00

And if you want to sort the report by a particular metric, hover your mouse over that metric's name and then click the arrow.

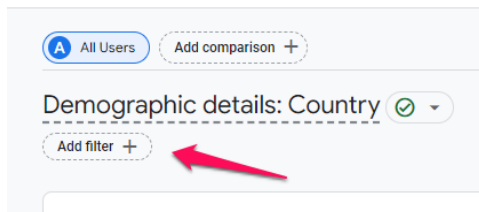
↓ Session primary...Channel Group) +		Key events purchase ▾	Session key event rate purchase ▾	↓ Total revenue
☐	Total	2,066.00 1.37% of total	1.73% Avg 0%	\$311,534.43 100% of total
☐	1 Unassigned	97.00	1.87%	\$6,829.58
☐	2 Referral	258.00	4.58%	\$31,284.71
☐	3 Paid Search	29.00	1.11%	\$10,873.94

Now, all your traffic sources are sorted by the top performers (revenue-wise).

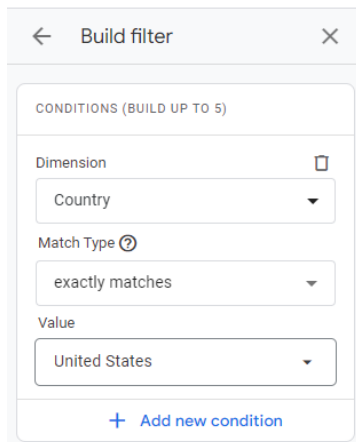
Session primary...Channel Group) +		Key events purchase ▾	Session key event rate purchase ▾	↓ Total revenue
☒	Total	2,066.00 1.37% of total	1.73% Avg 0%	\$311,534.43 100% of total
☒	1 Direct	1,078.00	1.38%	\$155,282.58
☒	2 Organic Search	307.00	1.34%	\$71,121.95
☒	3 Referral	258.00	4.58%	\$31,284.71
☒	4 Email	227.00	5.49%	\$27,522.23
☒	5 Paid Search	29.00	1.11%	\$10,873.94

Now, take some time to browse all standard reports and get more familiar with them. While, you're doing that, here are some additional tips:

- You can [link the Search Console to GA4](#). That way, additional data about Google Organic Search will be added to your property.
- *User Attributes > Demographic details* report can also show the age, gender, and interests of your visitors. To start collecting that data, you'll need to enable [Google Signals](#).
- The search field in the table is not the only way how you can see a subset of your data. You can also use [comparisons](#) and filters. If you want to add a filter temporarily (while you're analyzing), go to the detail report and click "Add filter" at the top.



Then add the rule, e.g., show data only of United States:



If you want a more permanent filter, I will show that in the next part of this e-book.

Part II

Customizing Standard Reports

While the standard reports in GA4 can provide some insights right out of the box, that may not always align with your unique needs.

Google Analytics 4 allows you to take its standard reports and tailor them to better reflect what matters most to your organization. Whether it's adjusting the metrics, adding new dimensions, or adding filters, customizing reports ensures that the data you're analyzing is as relevant and actionable as possible.

In this section, we'll explore the tools GA4 offers for customizing standard reports.

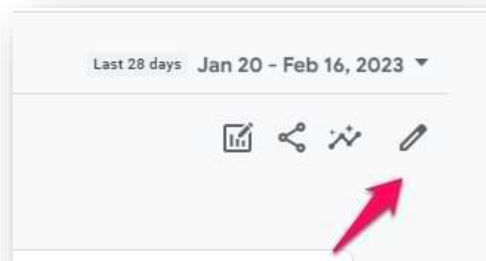
There are two places where you can customize the reports:

- You can either open any standard report and then click the Customize report button
- Or you can go to the Library and create/edit reports there

Remember, customized reports are visible to all users of a Google Analytics 4 property.

#2.1. Customize a single report in Google Analytics 4

To customize any single report, go to that report and click the Customize report button in the top-right corner.



If you don't see the button there, this means you don't have enough permissions in that property.

After you click the button, the interface will switch to report-editing mode. On the right side, a sidebar will appear containing the following sections:

- **Report data** (where you can manage dimensions and metrics). Available if you are editing the Detail report.
- **Report filter**. Available in the Detail report.
- **Charts**. Available in the Detail report.
- **Report template**. Available in the Detail report and an Overview report.
- **Summary cards**. Available in the Detail report.
- **Cards**. Available in an Overview report.

Dimensions. To add/remove primary dimensions, click the *Dimensions* button in the *Report data* section. These dimensions will be displayed as the first column of the report table. If multiple dimensions are included in this list, GA users will be able to select them in the dropdown of the first column.

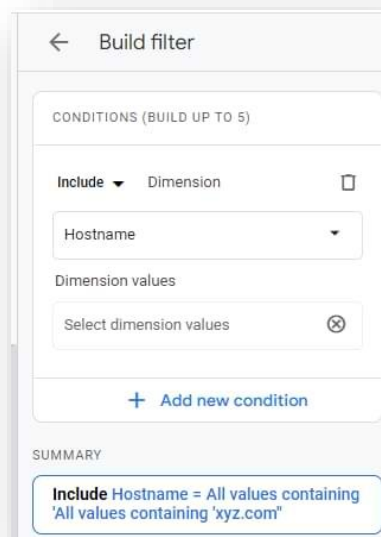
The screenshot displays the Google Analytics report editor. At the top, a line chart shows data for January 22, 29, and February 05. Below the chart, a legend identifies traffic sources: Organic Search (blue), Direct (orange), Email (green), Organic Video (purple), and Referral (brown). The main table has a search bar and a 'Ro' column. The first column is labeled 'Session default channel group' with a dropdown arrow and a plus sign. The second column is labeled 'Users' with a dropdown arrow and a plus sign. The table contains the following data:

	Session default channel group	Users
		94,509
1	Organic Search	81,434
2	Direct	7,388
3	Organic Video	2,337
4	Email	2,130
5	Referral	1,615
6	Organic Social	1,310
7	Unassigned	642

On the right side, a sidebar titled 'Dimensions' contains a section for 'PRIMARY DIMENSIONS'. It lists several dimensions with a plus icon and a dropdown arrow: 'Session default channel group' (Default), 'Session source / medium', 'Session medium', 'Session source', 'Session source platform', and 'Session campaign'. At the bottom of this section is an 'Add dimension' button with a dropdown arrow. Two red arrows point to the 'Session default channel group' dimension in the sidebar and the 'Session default channel group' header in the table. A red text overlay 'Dimensions from here' is positioned above the sidebar, and another red text overlay 'Will be available here' is positioned below the table header.

Metrics. Metrics are numbers that will be displayed in all other report columns. However, not all combinations of dimensions and metrics are possible. For example, you cannot combine item-scoped metrics/dimensions with event-scoped metrics/dimensions (e.g., item name and event count).

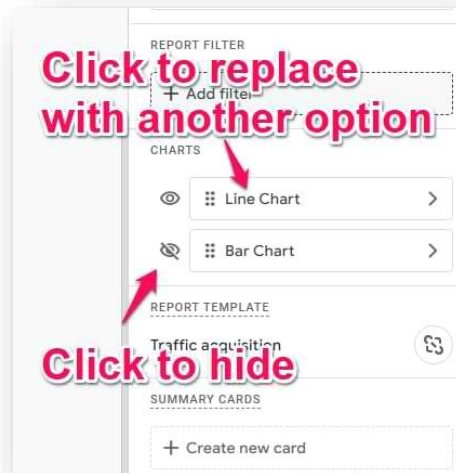
Report filter lets you add conditions and show a subset of your data. You can add up to 5 conditions in a filter. An example of a filter could be “Include hostname xxxxx.com” (this would show data only tracked on that hostname rather than all websites tracked by this GA property).



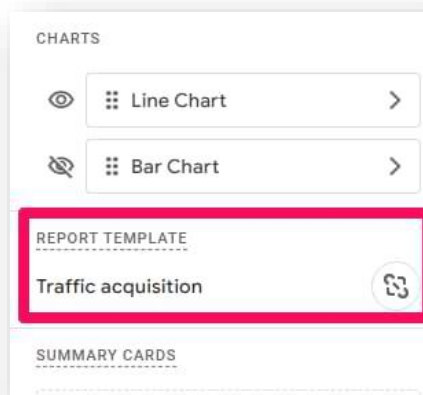
Charts. Currently, there are three types you can choose from:

- Bar chart
- Scatter chart
- Line chart

The only useful from this list (in my opinion) is the Line chart. That's the one that I keep enabled while others remain hidden.



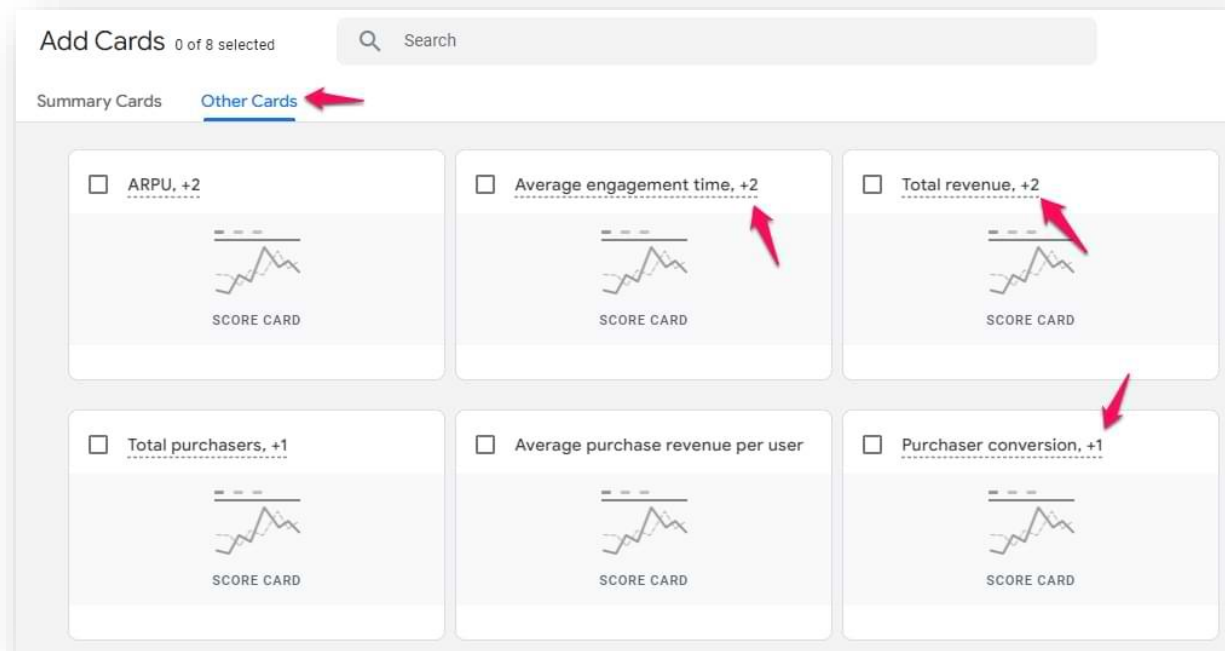
Report template. Occasionally, Google publishes updates to their standard reports (sometimes, they might even break them). So, if your report is linked to a standard template, it will be displayed like this:



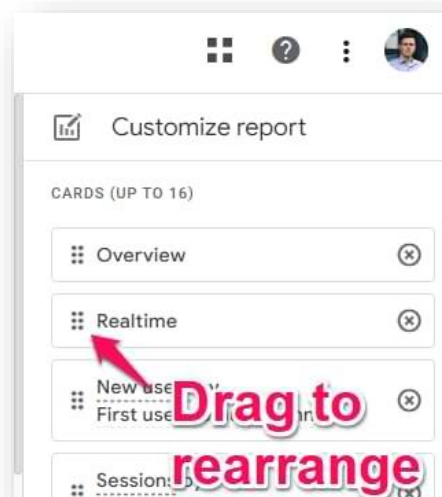
But sometimes, you might want to customize a report so that the link will eventually have to be broken. But don't worry. If you ever want to rebuild the report, you can create a new one from the Library (I will cover the GA4 library later in this e-book).

Cards. Here, you can add up to 16 cards (if you are customizing/building an overview report). You are free to rearrange them, and if you want to add a card, click Add Cards and then select from one of the available templates.

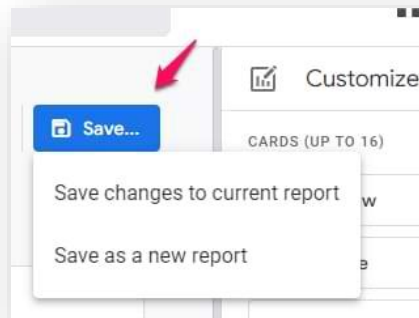
If one of the card templates has a number in it (e.g., +1 or +2), this means that there will be more than one metric available in the card.



Last (but not least), you can rearrange cards by dragging this icon:



Once you are done with the changes, click Save at the top right corner. Here you can select whether you want to save changes in the current report (or do you want to save it as a new report).



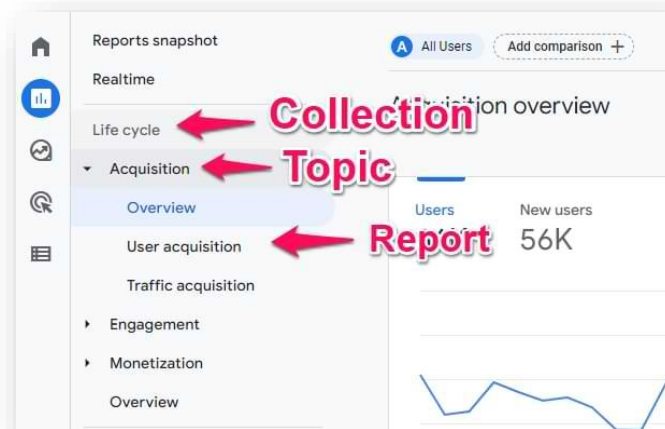
However, keep in mind that saving a new report will not make it visible on the sidebar. You will need to publish it later (and that's where you must become familiar with the Library).

#2.2. Library

Library is a place where you can manage your standard reports (default and customized). Here, you can group those reports into topics and collections and decide which reports have been published (meaning they will be visible on the sidebar).

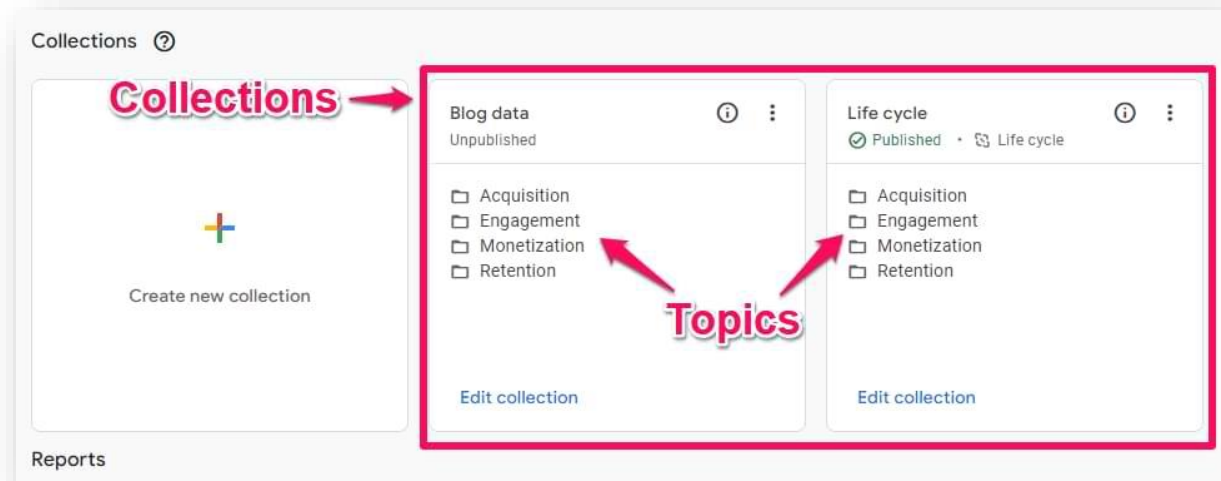
Collection is a top level of standard reports. By default, GA4 shows two collections of reports: Lifecycle and User (if you have selected "Other" or "Baseline" goal while creating the GA4 property).

If we drill down a bit, the next (lower) level is *Topic*. One collection can consist of several topics. For example, Lifecycle collection (by default) contains Acquisition, Engagement, and Monetization topics. Each topic consists of a set of reports.



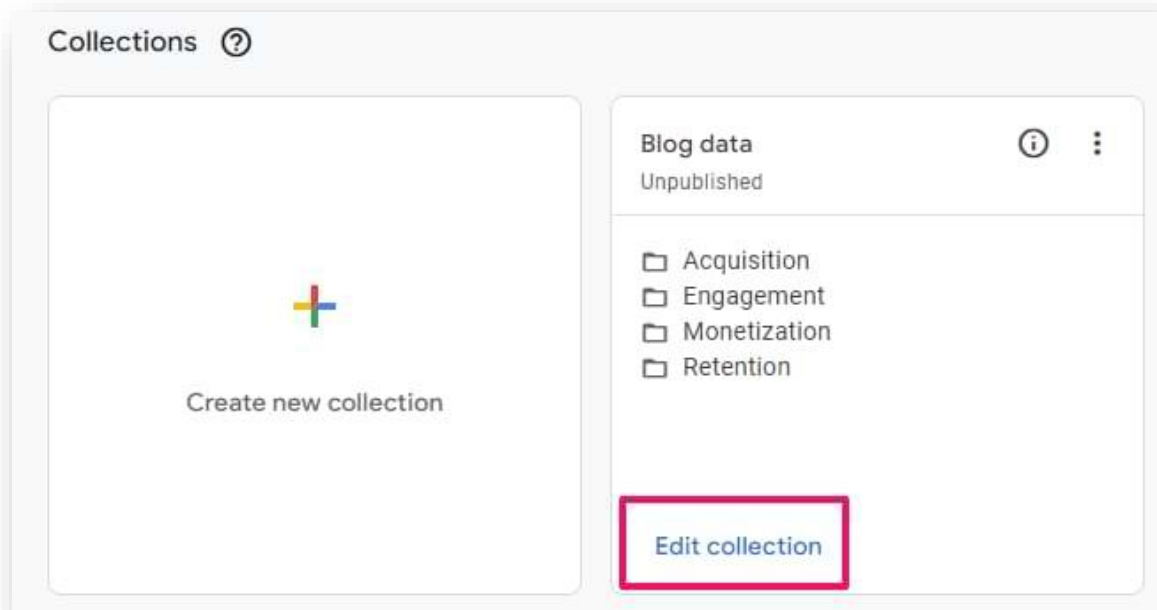
To get started, go to *Reports > Library*.

Here you will see a list of available (published and unpublished) collections. Inside a card of each collection, you will see a list of topics.



Below that list, you will see Reports. All of the default reports will already be there.

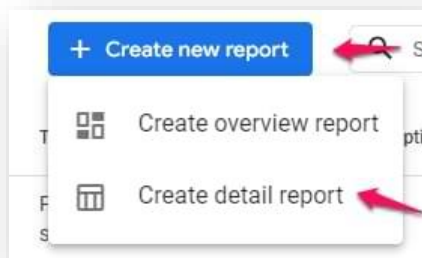
If you want to create a new GA4 collection, first, you need to click a large *Create new collection* button. To add a report to an existing collection, click *Edit collection*.



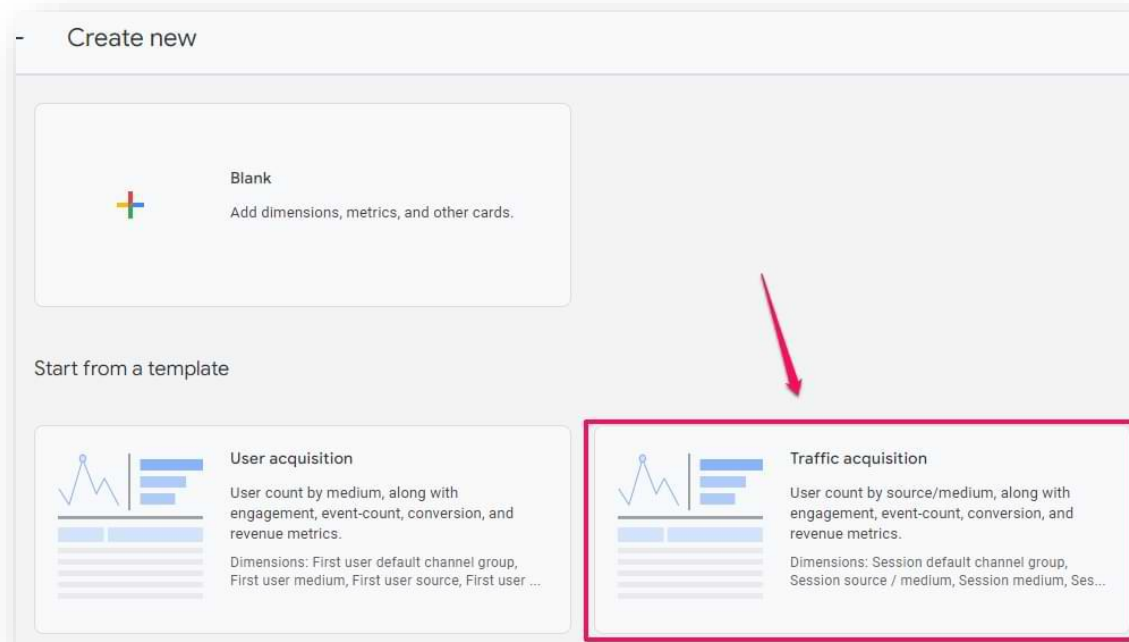
However, before you do that, you first have to create the actual report.

Let's say we want to build a report of only one subdomain (because maybe our property collects data from multiple subdomains). This will be a lightweight workaround for the views of Universal Analytics.

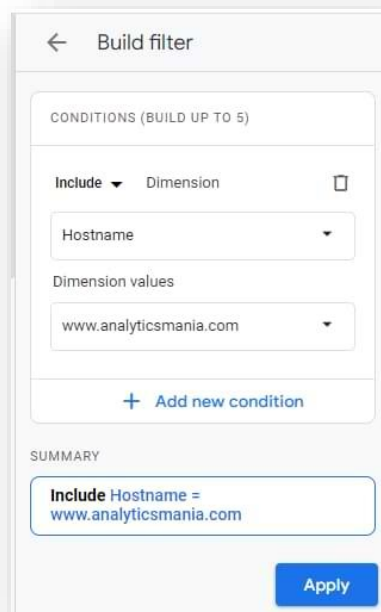
Click *Create new report* and then choose to *Create detail report*.



Let's say that in this report, we will be focusing on our top traffic sources. Select the *Traffic acquisition* template.



If you want, you can add/remove metrics and dimensions. In the *Report filter*, click *Add filter* and enter the following condition (obviously, you should use a different value of the hostname):

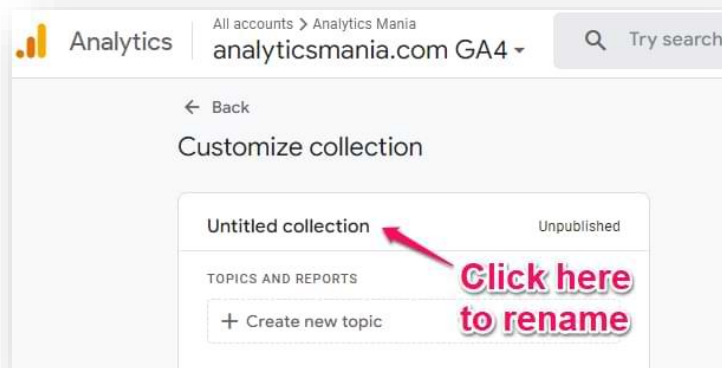


Click Apply.

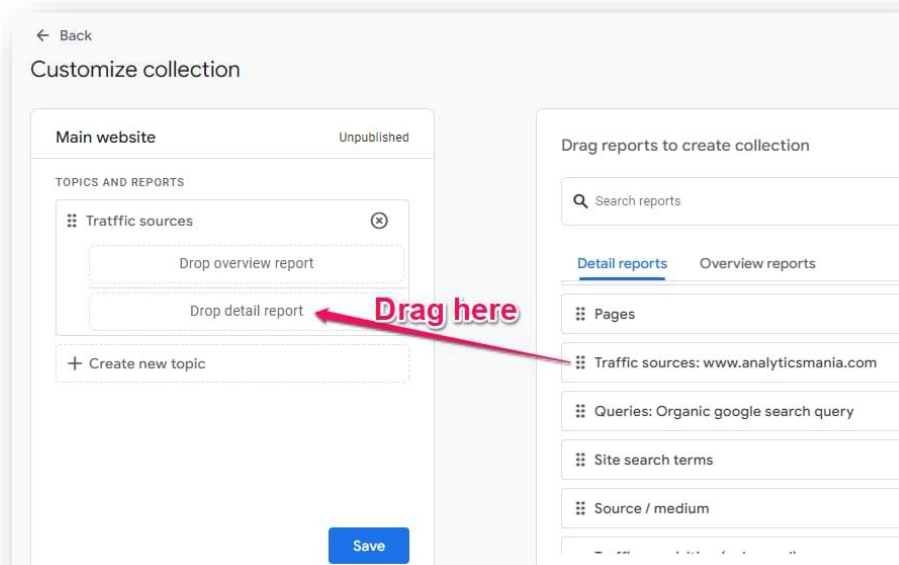
Once you are done with customizations, click Save and enter the report's name, for example, *Traffic sources: aaa.xxx.com*. Click Save.

Now, click *Back* and edit the collection where you want to include that report (because the report you just saved is still not included/visible in the left sidebar).

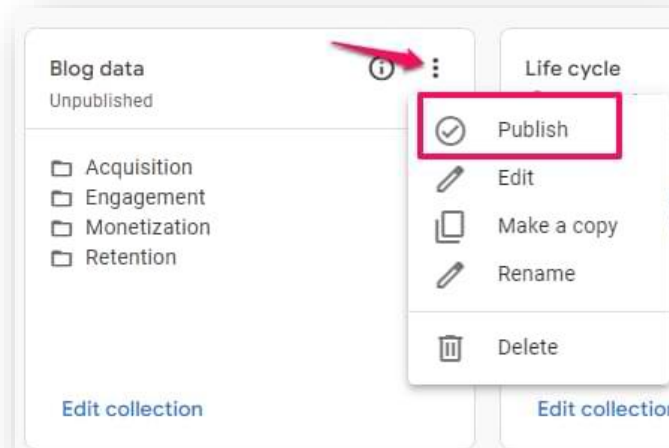
Let's say I want to create a collection of reports just for the *www.analyticsmania.com* subdomain. That's why I'll click *Create new collection > Blank*. Enter the name of your collection by clicking here:



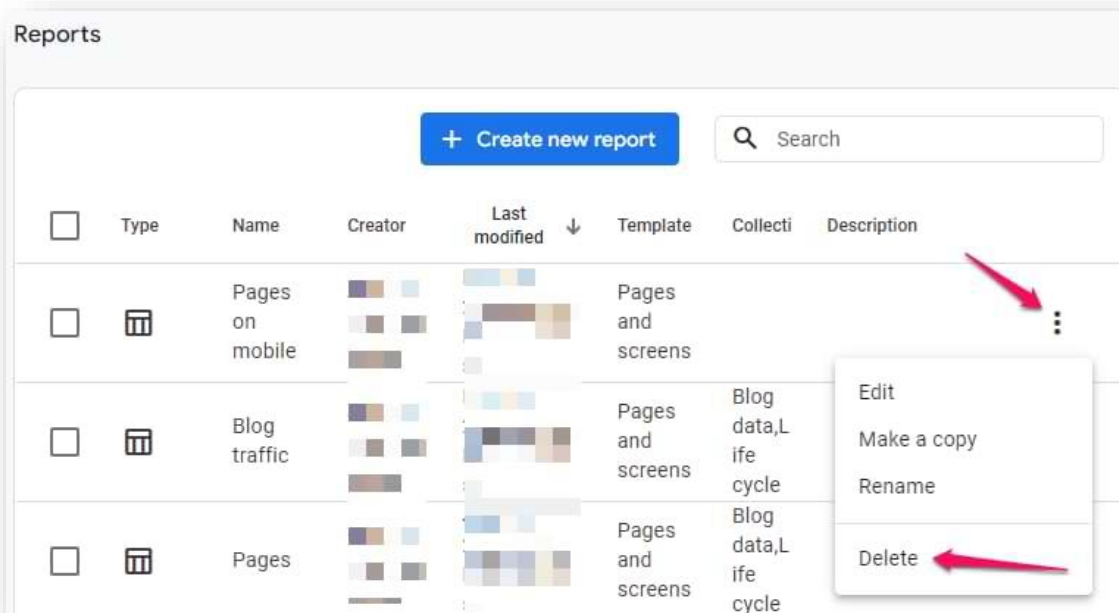
Then, you have to create at least one topic. In this case, I will enter "Traffic sources". After you create the topic, find your recently created report on the right and drag it to the left sidebar.



When you are done, click *Save*. Once you are done adding new reports to that collection, click three dots in the card of that new collection > Publish. This will make the collection and all of its reports visible on the left sidebar.



That's how you create or customize reports in Google Analytics 4. If you want to delete the report, click three dots next to that report in the Library.

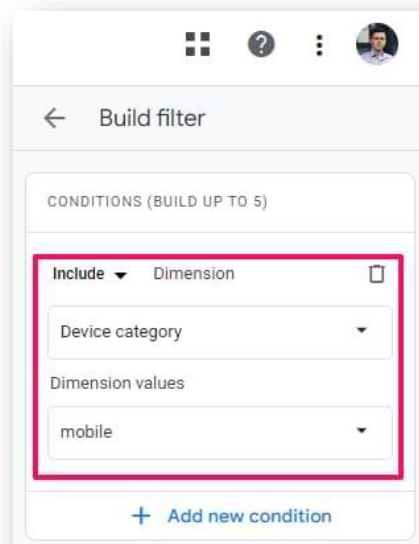


#2.3. Examples of customized reports

To give you some inspiration, here are several examples/ideas of what you can customize in GA4. I have already shown how to view data only of a particular subdomain/hostname. But here are more.

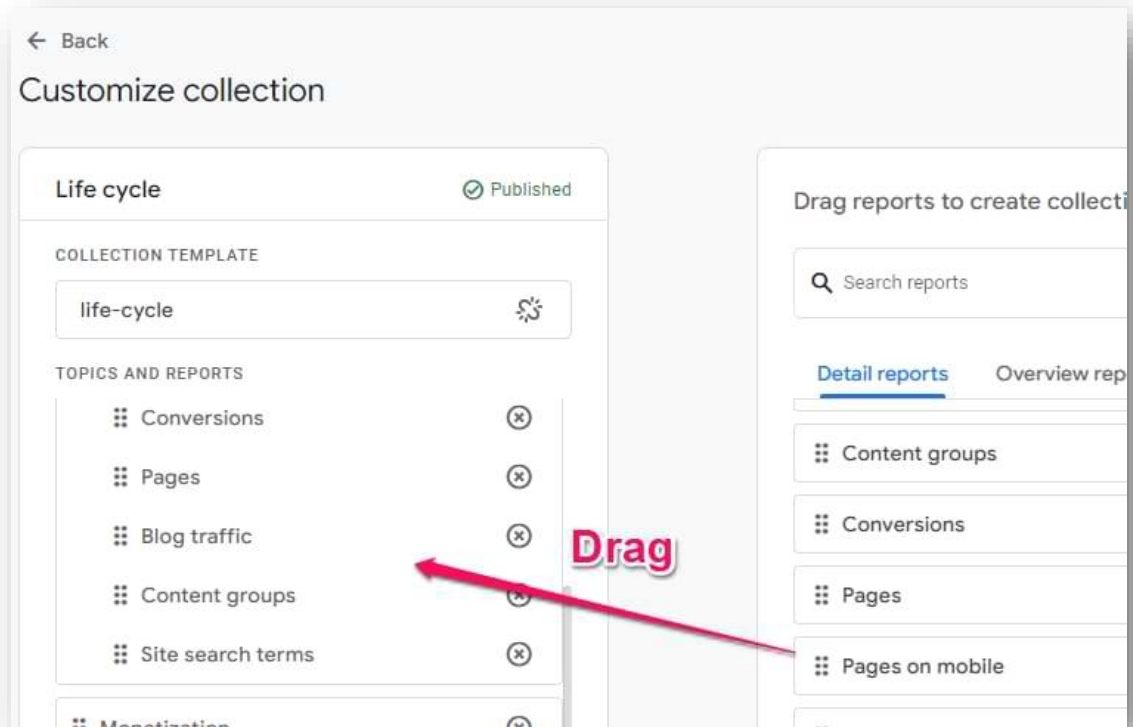
#2.3.1. Pages visited by mobile traffic

The easiest way to achieve this would be to open a standard report in *Reports > Engagement > Pages* and then click *Customize report*. Then keep all the settings as they are and add a filter: *device category* is *mobile*. Click Apply.



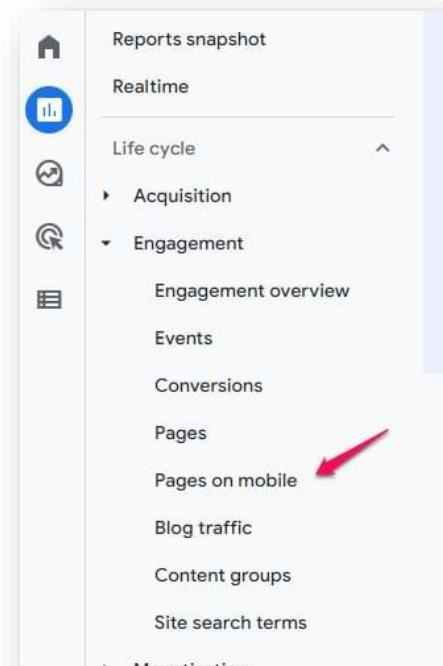
Then click *Save > Save as new report* and give it a name (e.g., Pages on mobile).

Go back to *Reports > Library* and edit the *Life cycle* collection (if you want to include the report in that collection). Now drag the newly created report to the *Engagement* topic and save the changes to the current collection.



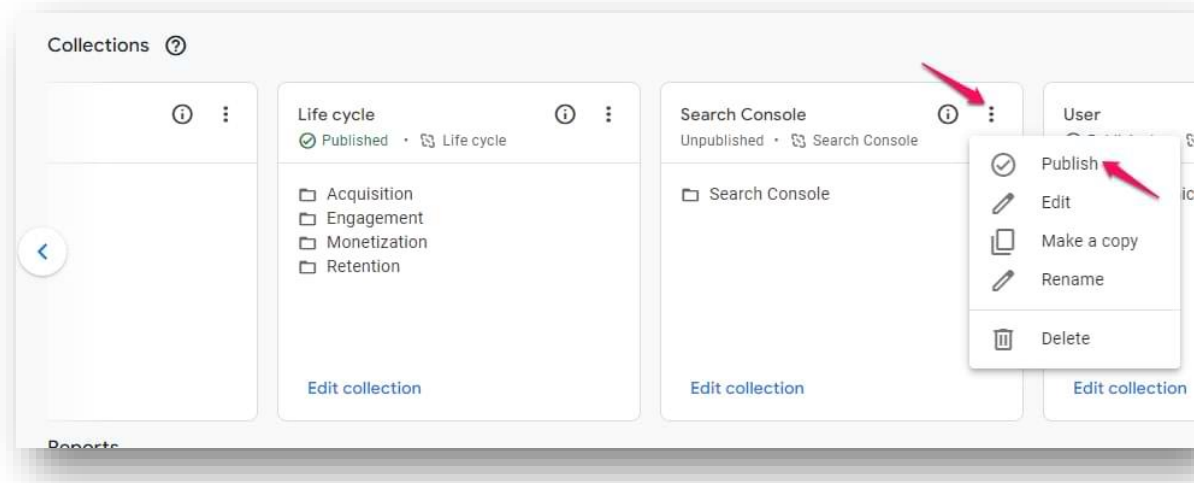
Done! Your report will look like this, and it can be accessed by going to *Reports > Engagement > Pages on mobile*.

All users of that GA4 property will be able to see/access that report.



#2.3.2. Google Search Console report

If you have connected [Google Search Console to your GA4 property](#), this connection automatically creates a new collection. Go to *Reports > Library* and keep looking for Search Console. Then click three dots next to it and hit Publish.



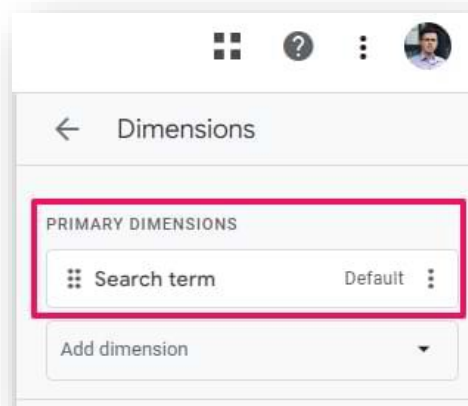
Honestly, I am surprised that this is needed at all. If I connect Search Console with GA4, I would expect to start seeing this report collection by default on the sidebar.

#2.3.3. Site search terms

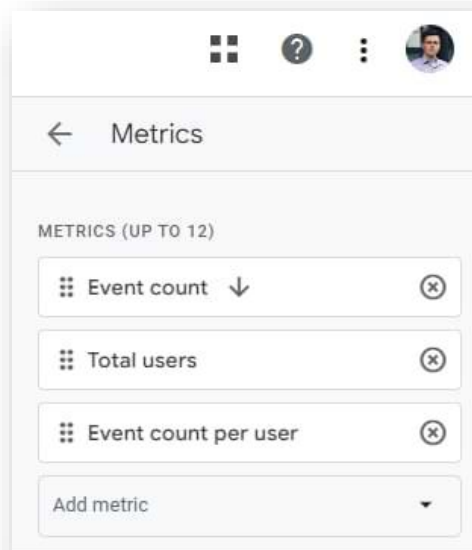
If your website [has a site search and you are tracking that with Google Analytics 4](#), you will have `view_search_results` in your reports. However, it would be more convenient to see a dedicated report for that event, where the primary dimension is the *search term*.

Luckily, with this customization feature, you can do that (although there are some caveats). Let's create a new report. Go to *Reports > Library > Create new report > Create detail report > Blank*.

In the Dimensions section, add the following: *Search term*. Click Apply.



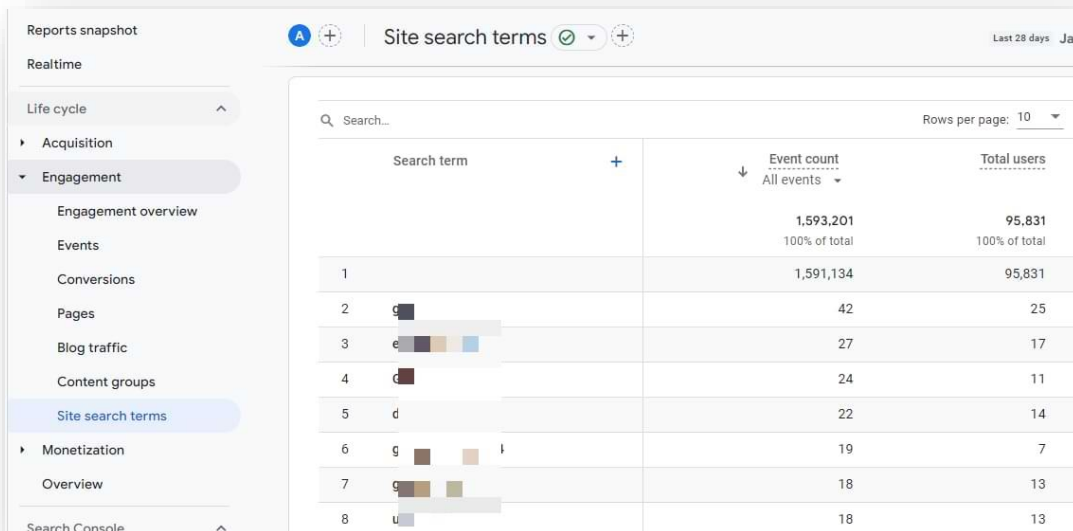
In the Metrics section, add the following metrics: *Event count*, *Total users*. If you want, you can also add *Event count per user* (maybe some users search the same thing multiple times).



Unfortunately, when I was writing this e-book, we could not create a filter that would include only *view_search_results* event. Maybe that will be fixed in the future, so go ahead and try creating a filter. But in my case, the *Event name* dimension is not available in the filters.

Hide all charts (except the Line Chart) by clicking Eye icons next to them. Click *Save* and give this report a name, e.g. *Site search*.

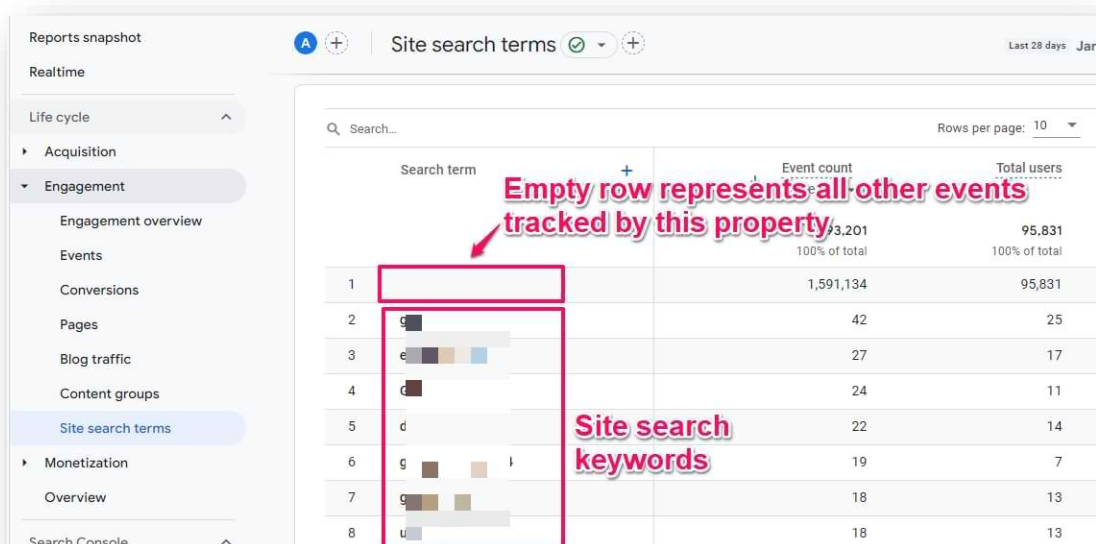
Finally, go back to the Library and include this report in one of the collections (e.g. *Life cycle > Engagement*). The final report will look like this:



Search term	Event count All events	Total users
	1,593,201 100% of total	95,831 100% of total
1	1,591,134	95,831
2	42	25
3	27	17
4	24	11
5	22	14
6	19	7
7	18	13
8	18	13

The reason why the first row of the report is empty is that we could not filter the data based on the event name. Right now, the first row includes all events that are not `view_seach_results`. You can either ignore this or [implement a workaround](#).

All other rows, on the other hand, will show proper data of how many times each keyword was searched and how many users were interested.



Search term	Event count All events	Total users
	1,593,201 100% of total	95,831 100% of total
1	1,591,134	95,831
2	42	25
3	27	17
4	24	11
5	22	14
6	19	7
7	18	13
8	18	13

#2.4. Limitations

Report customization in Google Analytics 4 has potential, but some important things are still missing.

For example, the previous example of site search keyword report. I wish we could create a filter based on the event name (without workarounds). That way, I could build a report on particular event(s).

Another limitation is that I cannot reuse the same report template in multiple GA4 properties/accounts. I wish I could build a custom collection and then export/import it to other properties. This feature would be very helpful for freelancers and agencies working with multiple clients.

Part III

Explorations

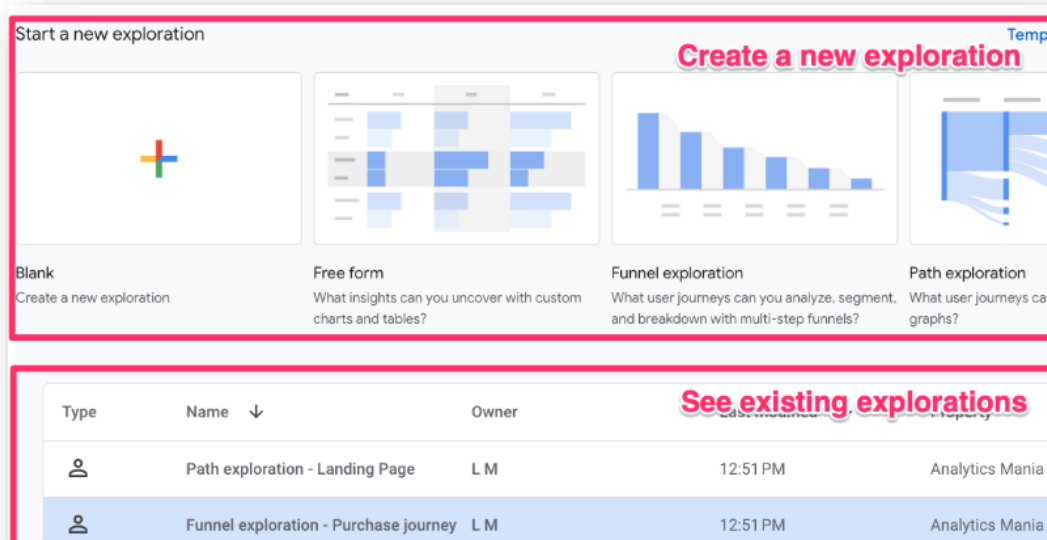
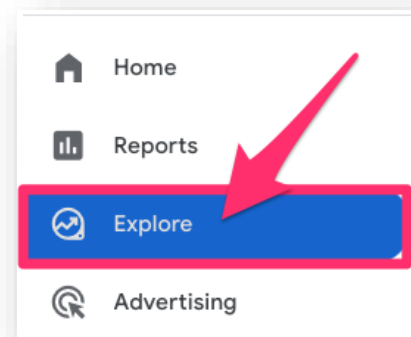
Sometimes, the Reports section of GA4 is not enough and you need to go deeper (for example, include 3 dimensions at the same time or build a funnel). That's where Explorations join the game.

In this section, we'll introduce you to the core features of GA4's Explorations. You'll learn how to create your own exploratory reports, use advanced techniques like funnel analysis and pathing.

#3.1. Navigating to GA4 explorations

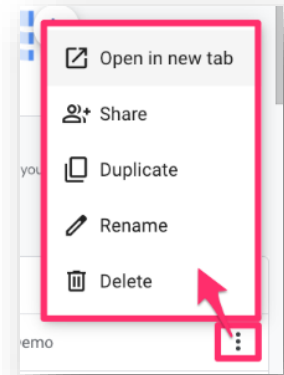
To find the GA4 Explorations, go to the left-hand navigation and click "Explore".

This will take you to the Explorations landing page, where you can create a new exploration by selecting a blank report or technique, or view the explorations you and others in the property have created and shared.



On the right end of each row is a list of actions you can select.

Notably, the “Share” option allows you to share any explorations that you own with everyone else in the same property, and “Duplicate” allows you to make a copy of your own report and any reports that others have shared (since these are shared as read-only, you need to make a copy to make any modifications).



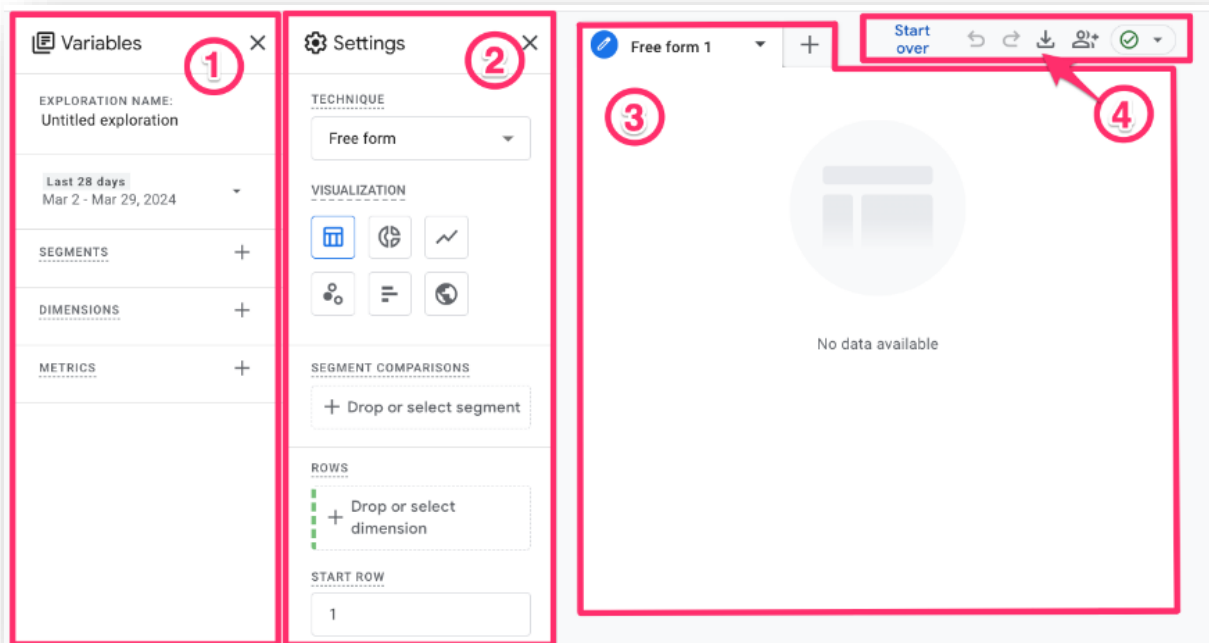
#3.2. Types of exploration techniques

- **Free-form:** As the name suggests, this technique offers a lot of variety of visualization to explore your data. Analyze and compare metrics and dimensions through different visualizations, like tables and time series charts, and use segments or filters to refine your analysis further.
- **Funnel exploration:** Examine users’ steps through a predefined conversion funnel, pinpointing areas where users drop off and identifying improvement opportunities.
- **Path exploration:** Without any set path in mind, uncover how users wander around your site, whether moving forward from a starting point or retracing steps backward from an ending point.
- **Segment overlap:** Compare multiple user segments to identify commonalities and differences in behavior, helping refine targeting strategies and personalize user experiences.
- **User explorer:** Dive deeper into individual user behavior, tracking engagement across multiple sessions to understand a user’s journey and preferences.
- **Cohort exploration:** Group users based on shared attributes and analyze how these groups (cohorts) change over time, providing insights into what could affect user retention.
- **User lifetime:** Explore user behavior and value over their lifetime as visitors, guiding retention strategies.

#3.3. Overview of the interface

An exploration has four main sections (the image shows the interface for a Free form exploration):

1. **Variables:** The selected elements in this section stay consistent across all tabs of the exploration.
2. **Settings:** These are tab- and technique-specific elements.
3. **Output and tabs:** This is where the data will populate, and you can add additional tabs to the report.
4. **Toolbar:** Additional components related to data and sharing.



Note: GA4 Explorations will automatically save, so if you exit the page accidentally or your browser shuts down on you, no worries, all your work will still be there.

#3.3.1. Variables

- **Exploration name:** Even if you are the only one with access to the property, it's frustrating to know that you have created a report but need to look through all explorations to find it because you didn't name it well (or at all). So, use good [naming conventions](#) when naming your explorations.
- **Date:** Select any date range up to the start of tracking. If you notice that you can only go back two months, even though you know you have more data than that, the property's data retention has likely not been updated. Read more about how to fix this issue [here](#) (note that this will only fix the issue going forward, not retroactively).
 - Additionally, you can add a comparison date which will show all values in your report for the original date range you have selected and another date range. You could compare the values of the previous year or of the previous time period.
- **Segments, Dimensions & Metrics:** You can import up to 20 dimensions, 20 metrics, and 10 segments into an exploration. Double-click, drag or click on the landing spot (Segment comparison, Rows, Columns or Values) to add a variable to the report.
 - [Segments](#) are used to slice and dice data by grouping subsets of users based on given criteria, like demographics or acquisition sources.
 - **Dimensions** are attributes of your data, typically in text, boolean (true or false) or date format, which can provide context to metrics.
 - **Metrics** are numeric values representing a measurable quantity, including calculated metrics (creating new metrics out of existing ones).

#3.3.2. Settings

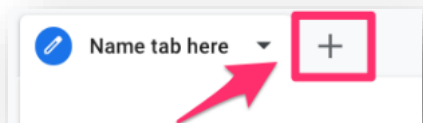
The options in this section vary by technique. Technique-specific options will be mentioned in their specific section below, but these are the most common ones (taken from free-form exploration).

- **Technique:** You can choose the technique from within a report, and you can have multiple techniques in a single report by adding more tabs.
- **Visualization:** Not all techniques have this option. You can change the visualization when using the Free form and Funnel techniques. For the Free form technique, you have: table, donut, line chart, scatterplot, bar chart, and geo map visualizations. For the Funnel technique, you can use a standard or trended funnel.
- **Segment comparisons:** Add [segments](#) to the report to compare different subsets of users by double-clicking the segment, dragging it or selecting it by clicking on this element.
- **Rows, Columns and Values:** Dimensions can go into rows or columns, and metrics can go into values by double-clicking, dragging or selecting the dimensions or metric from the list by clicking on one of these elements. The report needs at least one metric in the values to populate any data.
 - The report will show ten rows and five columns by default, but you can adjust it to 500 rows and 20 columns.
- **Cell type:** Changes how you can present metrics in a tabular visualization.
- **Filters:** Allows you to restrict the data in the report by creating conditions based on both dimensions and metrics. Be sure to click “Apply” once you have inputted the filter conditions. You can apply up to 10 filters per tab.

#3.3.3. Output and tabs

This is where the data will populate after applying at least one metric. The data will automatically update with changes to elements in the “Settings” section.

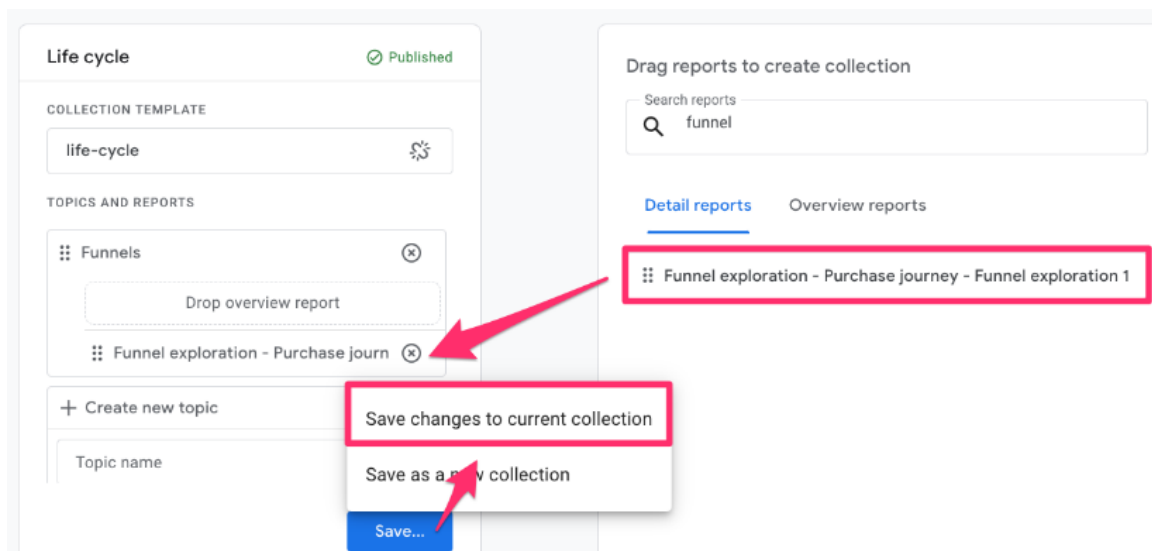
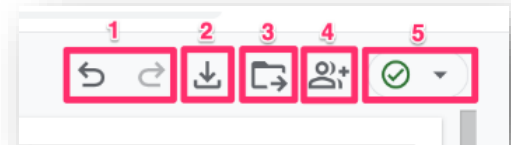
You can add a new tab by clicking the “+” at the top of the interface. To keep things organized, be sure to name the tabs.



You can have up to 10 tabs per exploration with any combination of techniques. The “Variables” section will stay consistent throughout the exploration, but the “Settings” section will be tab-specific.

#3.3.4. Toolbar

1. Undo and redo any actions.
2. Export data into Google Sheets, TSV, CSV, and PDF (current or all tabs).
3. [This only applies to the funnel exploration technique] Save as a report in the Library so you can add your funnel exploration to the standard reports by editing a collection. Go to *Reports > Library > Select a collection* and click “Edit” from the menu actions. Find the funnel exploration, drag it over, and “save to current collection”.



4. Share the report with others in the same GA4 property. The report will be read-only, so no one else can modify the report. However, those with the Analyst and above roles can make a copy of the report and then make changes to their own version.
5. The data quality icon will provide you with more information about the data being used in the report, like sampling and thresholding.

- A green circle with a checkmark indicates that your report is not sampled.
- A yellow triangle will tell you that you have [data thresholding](#), sampling, or another similar issue.
- A red circle with an “!” means your data is heavily sampled. Here, you can make two (or three, if you’re in a 360 property) selections:
 - “Load report faster”, which will maintain the sampled data.
 - “More detailed results” will take more time, but reduce the amount of sampling or eliminate it completely.
 - “Request unsampled report” allows 360 property users to request a read-only unsampled report. This report will load the unsampled data of the current tab in a new tab after a few minutes (so if you have 10 tabs, this won’t work). The unsampled reports are static (won’t change over time) and automatically deleted after 50 days. By requesting an unsampled report, your explorations will be automatically shared with the property.

#3.4. Limitations of explorations

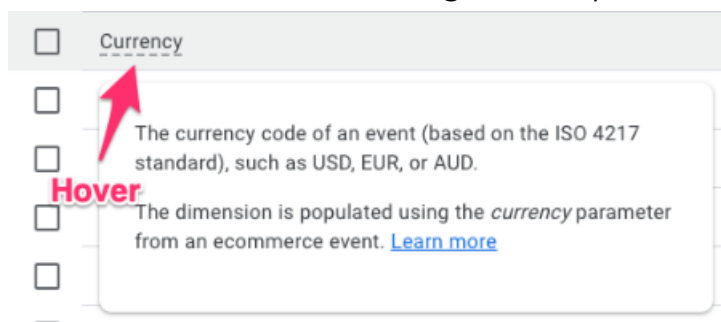
It’s always best to enter a situation understanding any limits or limitations so that you can best prepare, especially if you’re just starting out; it’s easier to plan ahead than make adjustments later.

- You can create up to 200 individual explorations per user per property and up to 500 shared explorations per property.
- There can be 20 dimensions, 20 metrics and 10 segments per exploration, and 10 filters per tab.
- You cannot resize the columns of a report.
- For unsampled reports, each 360 property has a quota of 300 tokens per property per day for all users, which can query up to 15 million total events across explorations. These daily limits reset at midnight Pacific time. Unsampled reports are not available for the User lifetime technique.

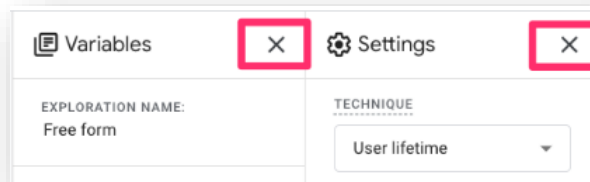
- Shared Explorations are only available in read-only mode, so if you want to modify a shared report, you need to “Duplicate” the report.
- Limitations of specific techniques:
 - The default metric of the funnel exploration is users, and it cannot be changed.
 - The Cohort exploration will ignore User ID and only look at device data (e.g. cookies).
 - When looking at an individual user in the user explorer report, there is a lack of descriptive information, e.g. you are unable to see on which page a specific event occurred.

#3.5. Hot tips

- If you’re just getting into GA4 Explorations for the first time, or you have been doing it for a while, you may not always remember what every single component of the report means. Luckily, Google has made things easy for us and explained many of the report’s elements, as well as most built-in dimensions and metrics.
 - To see an explanation, just hover your mouse over anything with a dotted underline. This is great if you need a quick reminder.

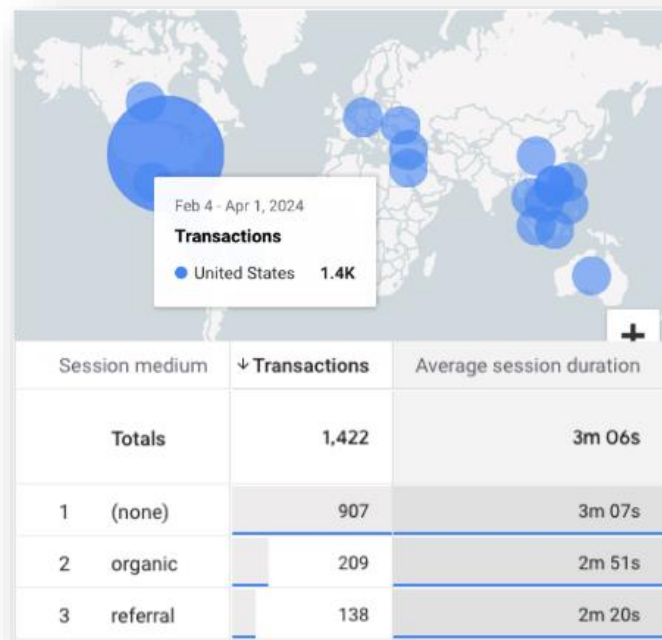


- You can close the Variables and Settings tab to create a larger area for your visualizations to populate. This makes it easier to see more data at a time since you cannot adjust the sizes of the columns and rows.



#3.6. Free form exploration

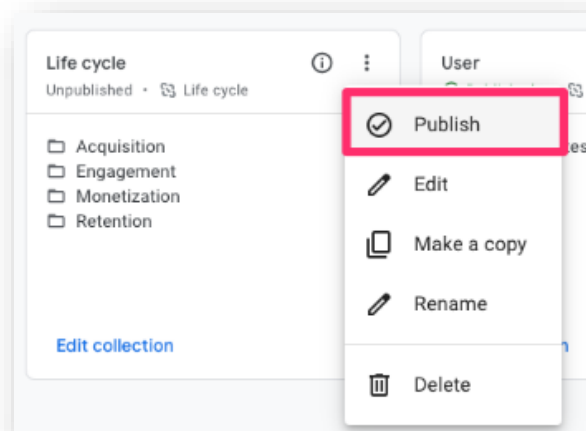
If I had to guess, free-form explorations are probably the most used technique. They can be used to create versatile tabular data visualizations (along with donut charts, line charts, scatterplots, bar charts, and geo maps) tailored to specific business needs. I usually go here first when trying to answer a question about user behavior.



#3.6.1. Example 1: Rebuild the standard Events report

Free-form exploration is the technique to use if you want to recreate any of the standard reports but customize the dimensions, metrics, filters, or segments.

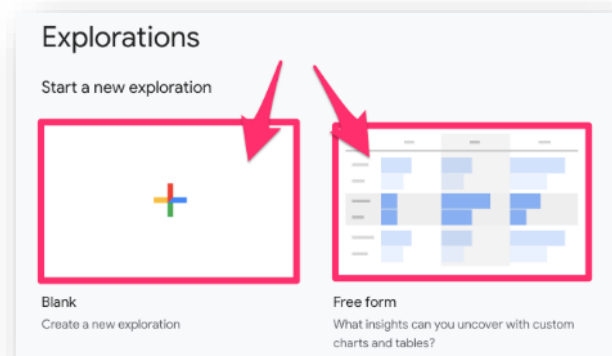
The Event standard report is found in the built-in Lifecycle collection, which you can add to your property by going to *Reports > Library* and selecting “Publish” from the menu items.



To access the report, go to *Reports > Engagement > Events*. Here, you can see the dimension is the event name, and various metrics are included. What if you want to add a new metric, like sessions, or remove a metric, like transactions, or add a permanent secondary dimension, like an event parameter?

Unless you are the property’s Editor or Administrator, you can’t do this. But fear not—this is where GA4 explorations shine! Let’s recreate this report to suit our exact needs!

Method #1: From scratch. From the Explorations landing page, choose “Blank” or “Free-form”. When you click on a specific technique from this page, the report will be prepopulated with dimensions, metrics, and/or segments.



Since you can change the technique from within the report, I prefer to always start with a blank report so that I don't need to remove the prepopulated elements.

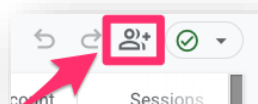
For the recreation of the Events report, I will include:

- Dimensions: *Event name*
- Metrics: *Event count*, *Active users*, *Event count per user* and *Sessions*

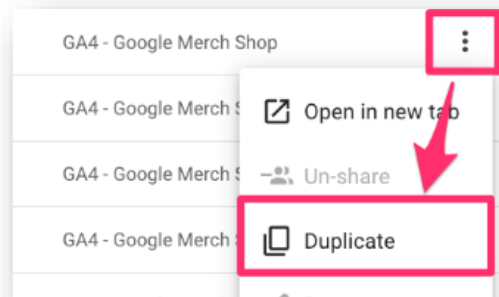
Double-click on each dimension and metric to add them to the report. Once the first metric has been added, the data will begin to populate. To change how the data is sorted, click on the heading of the metric or dimension you wish to sort by. Don't forget to also adjust the number of rows to show more data.

Event name	Event count	Active users	Event count per user	Sessions
Totals	165,767	7,117	23.29	9,697
1 page_view	35,305	7,117	4.97	8,874
2 user_engagement	30,521	5,667	5.39	7,077
3 view_item_list	19,360	5,297	3.65	6,442
4 scroll	17,125	4,751	3.6	5,481
5 new_recent_active_user	10,783	4,967	2.17	5,166
6 view_item	10,443	3,744	2.79	4,474
7 session_start	9,127	6,766	1.35	9,231
8 first_visit	5,496	5,482	1	5,594
9 view_cart	4,763	792	6.01	924
10 predicted_top_spenders	4,329	130	33.3	87

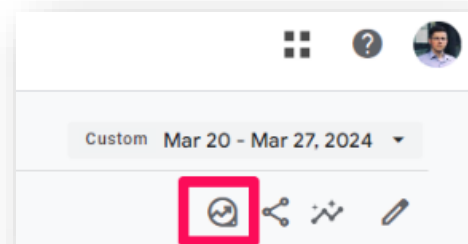
The report will automatically save, so there is nothing else you need to do unless you want to share it with others. Then click on the sharing icon in the top right corner to share a read-only version of the report with others.



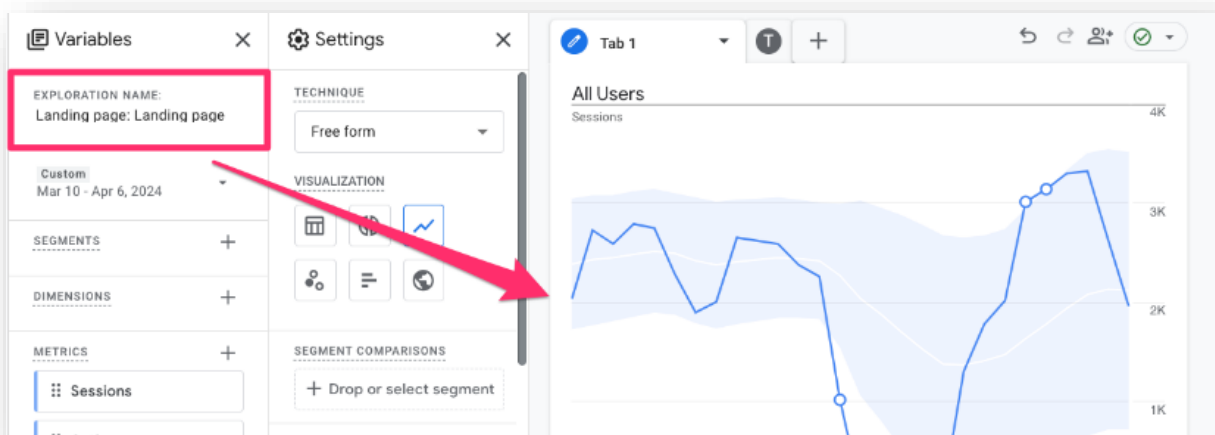
As a reminder, the report is shared as read-only, so no one else can modify your original report. However, those with the Analyst and above roles can “Duplicate” the report from the list of Explorations and then make changes to their own version.



Method #2: Shortcut from standard report. If that seemed like a few too many steps for you, there is actually a quicker way to do this! All you need to do is open up the standard report that you want to recreate and find the “Export this report to analysis” icon below the date picker.



This will open up the report as an exploration, so you can make any adjustments that you need for it to better suit your business needs, including adding segments, filters, and additional dimensions and metrics.

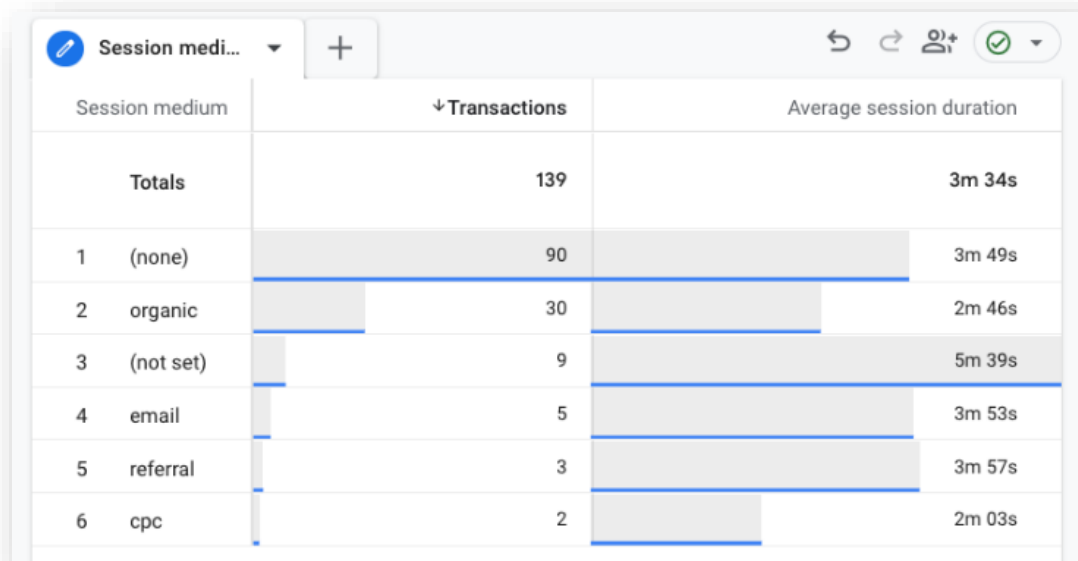


#3.6.2. Example 2: Which marketing channels drive the highest-quality traffic?

Understanding which marketing channels drive the highest-quality traffic helps optimize budget allocation and refine targeting strategies. Ultimately, if you want to ensure that you are maximizing the returns on your investments, you need to keep track of how different marketing methods compare to each other.

To a blank report, add:

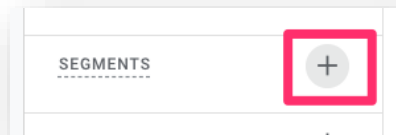
- Dimension: *Session medium* (you can expand this to include *Session source* and *Session campaign* too)
- Metrics: *Transactions*, *Average session duration*



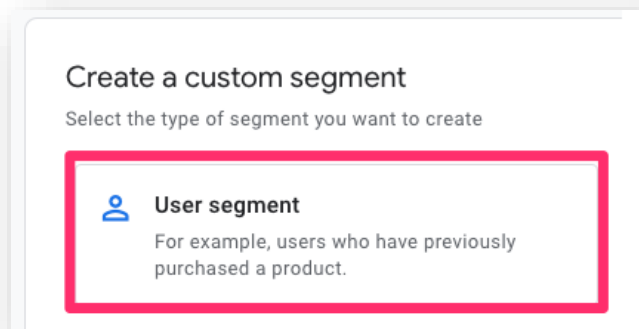
The screenshot shows a report interface with a table and horizontal bar charts. The table has three columns: 'Session medium', '↓ Transactions', and 'Average session duration'. The data is as follows:

Session medium	↓ Transactions	Average session duration
Totals	139	3m 34s
1 (none)	90	3m 49s
2 organic	30	2m 46s
3 (not set)	9	5m 39s
4 email	5	3m 53s
5 referral	3	3m 57s
6 cpc	2	2m 03s

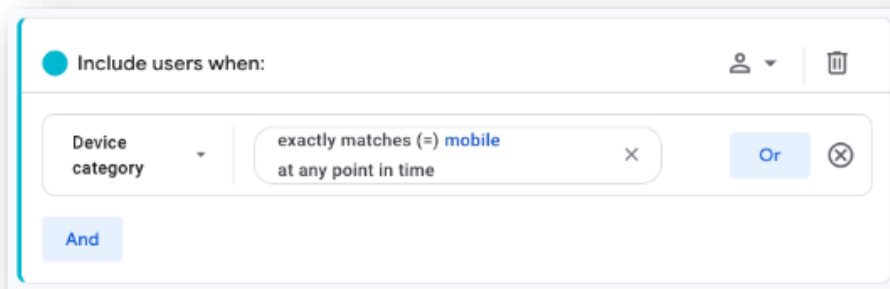
To explore the data further, you can create two segments that compare the actions between mobile and desktop users. Click the “+” next to Segments to create the two segments.



Click “User segment”.



For the mobile traffic segment, add “Device category exactly matches mobile”, name the segment “Mobile traffic”, and click “Save and apply” (which will apply the segment to the report).



For the desktop traffic segment, add “Device category exactly matches desktop”, name the segment “Desktop traffic”, and click “Save and apply”.

Include users when:

Device category

exactly matches (=) desktop

×

at any point in time

×

Or

×

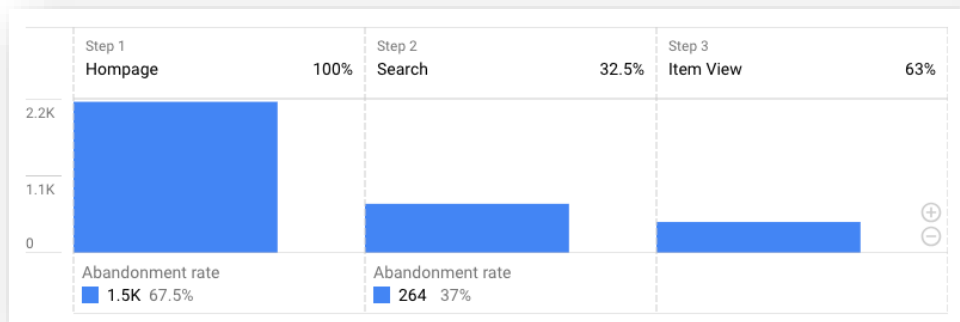
And

Now, you can start to look for insights in the data, like why emails lead to higher-quality traffic when users are on their desktops compared to mobile.

Segment	Desktop traffic		Mobile traffic	
Session medium	Transactions	Average session duration	Transactions	Average session duration
Totals	130	4m 16s	19	2m 21s
1 (none)	84	4m 23s	12	2m 33s
2 organic	27	3m 36s	6	1m 50s
3 (not set)	9	6m 16s	0	5m 47s
4 email	5	3m 54s	0	1m 42s
5 referral	3	4m 22s	1	3m 36s
6 cpc	2	2m 32s	0	1m 24s

#3.7. Funnel exploration

Funnel explorations enable you to analyze the completion and abandonment rates along a pre-defined user journey, which can help you identify bottlenecks in specific paths on your site. Identifying obstacles along these paths can help improve the user experience by pinpointing areas where users encounter difficulties.

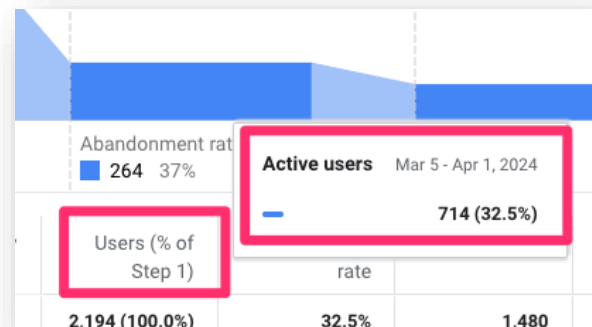


Under the Settings tab, some components are unique to funnel explorations:

- **Open vs. closed funnel:** In a closed funnel, visitors must have started from the first step, but in an open funnel, users can be included in the funnel at any step (even if they didn't complete the one before).
 - For example, if your funnel includes steps A, B, and C, a user could have completed only steps B and C and still be included in the funnel, whereas in a closed funnel, the user needs to start at step A.
- **Steps:** This is where you specify the steps of the funnel. A single funnel can have up to 10 steps, which can be a combination or multiple dimensions.
 - For example, step 1 could require the user to view a specific page, and step 2 could require the user to complete a particular event, and so on.
- **Breakdown:** Include any additional dimension to break down the visualization, such as device category or city. You can see up to 15 rows of dimension values per step. Users will only be attributed to the first instance of the breakdown value that applies to them, e.g. if the user starts the funnel on mobile but completes the last step on a tablet, they will only be counted under mobile throughout the funnel steps.
- **Show elapsed time:** By turning this on, you can see the average time between each step.
- **Next action:** When you hover over the bars in the visualization, it will show the top five actions users took after each step, so you can see where users are going beyond the pre-defined step.

For the visualization, you can choose between a standard or trended funnel. The standard funnel shows a snapshot of the funnel performance aggregated over the period, and the trended funnel shows the daily funnel performance over the period.

One last thing to note is that you cannot change the metrics used in the funnel, as it will always include user metrics (count and percentage).



#3.7.1. Example: How many visitors are dropping off on their purchase journey?

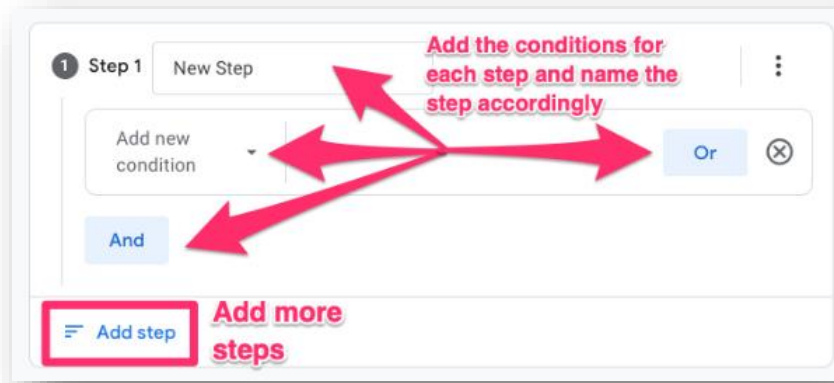
If you have implemented E-Commerce tracking with Google Analytics 4, then you are probably interested in knowing at what points in the purchase process users drop off. While funnel exploration cannot tell you *why* users are dropping off, it can provide insights that you can use to investigate areas of your site.

Add steps

To get started, click the pencil icon next to “Steps”.



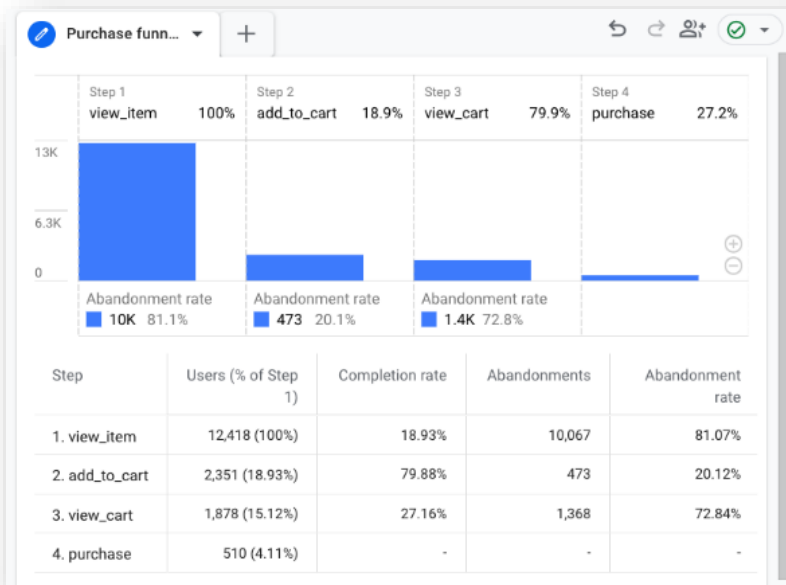
This will load a new view that allows you to identify the steps you want to follow for your funnel, which can be made up of a combination of events, parameters, or pages.



This funnel involves the use of e-commerce events, which requires additional configuration since these events are not automatically tracked by GA4. A complete GA4 ecommerce setup with Google Tag Manager is available in my [Intermediate/Advanced GTM course](#).

The steps for this funnel are: (this is just a guide, so feel free to adjust this to what works for you)

- Step 1: *Event name* exactly matches *view_item*
- Step 2: *Event name* exactly matches *add_to_cart*
- Step 3: *Event name* exactly matches *view_cart*
- Step 4: *Event name* exactly matches *purchase*



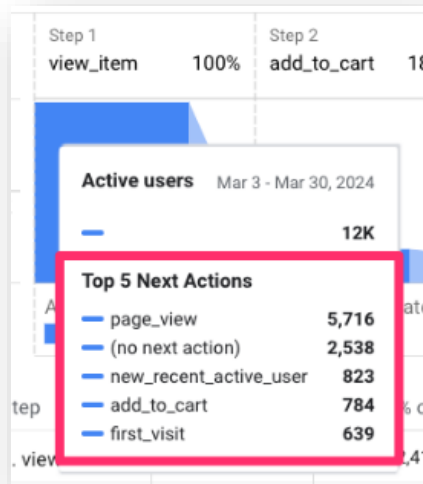
Add a breakdown

Add the *Device category* as a dimension and drag it into the “Breakdown” to see if any device-specific differences in the funnel need to be addressed.

4. purchase	Total	10h 00m	510 (4.11%)
	desktop	9h 47m	449 (5.7%)
	mobile	11h 43m	60 (1.41%)
	tablet	2m 22s	1 (0.43%)
	smart tv	-	0 (0%)

Add the next action

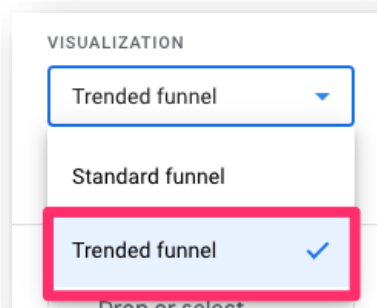
Add *Event Name* as a dimension and drag it into the “Next action” to see the top five subsequent actions for each step.



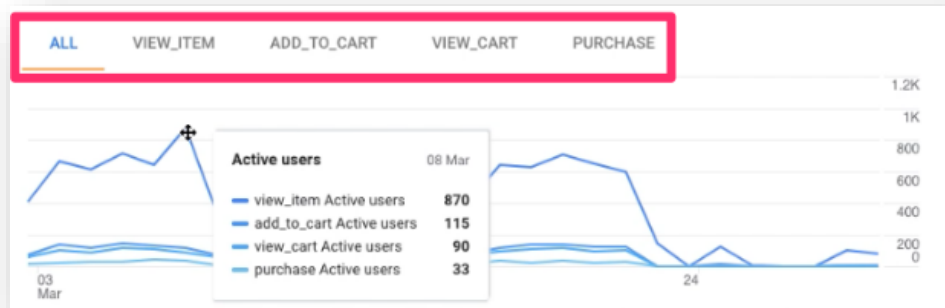
Trended funnel and comparison

Let's say we want to look at the trended funnel and compare the daily values for this year compared to last year.

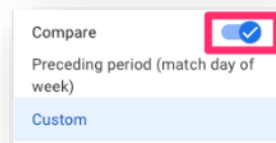
Change the visualization from standard to trended. I will also remove the breakdown and the next action to simplify the visualization.



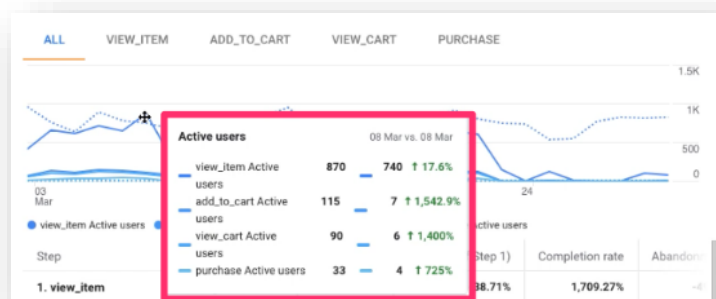
You can view each step in a single time series chart or change the tabs to view just a single step in the funnel.



To compare these values to the previous year, go to the date range, toggle on “Compare” and select the same dates as the last year.



Now, for each day, you will be able to see the values for the current time period and the comparison time period to see how behavior has changed over time. This is especially helpful when you have made changes to your site and want to know the impact those changes have on users.



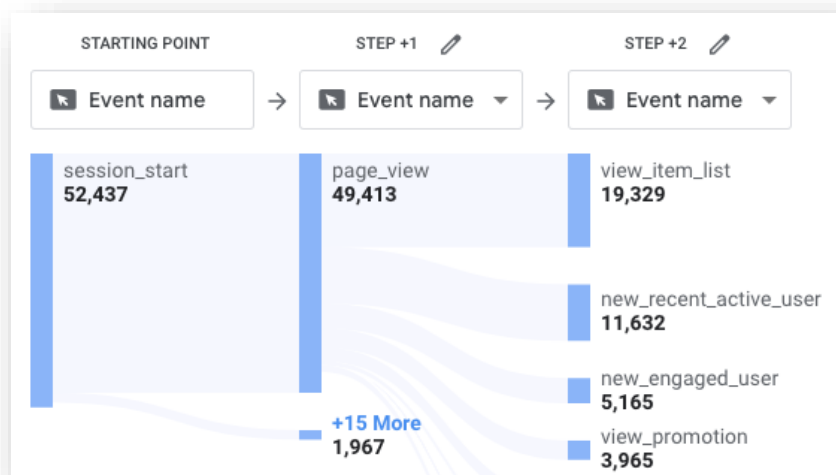
Note: Users are only attributed to the first date they were active in a step. So, if a user completed a purchase (and all previous steps) multiple times, they will only be

counted once, and that would be on the date they first made a purchase in the time period.

You can also add up to 4 segments to your funnel exploration if you want to further compare multiple user groups at a time.

#3.8. Path exploration

Path exploration is good if you don't have a specific journey in mind and are just curious about what users are doing. These paths can help uncover unexpected behaviour and any looping that users may be experiencing.

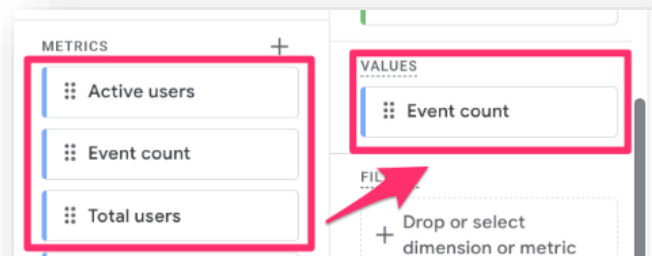


Under the Settings tab, some components are unique to path explorations:

- **Nodes:** A node is a branch in the path exploration visualization. You can use four pre-defined dimensions for each step of the process and any combination of these dimensions across the path (you don't need to stick to just one).
- **View unique nodes only:** When toggled on, this feature removes any nodes that appear after an identical node.

- For example, if a user's actions are as follows: *click > click > page_view* (*click* occur consecutively), then enabling only unique nodes will turn this into: *click > page_view*.
- **Breakdown:** Include an additional dimension, like the device category, to break down the visualization. You can view up to 5 rows of dimension values per node.

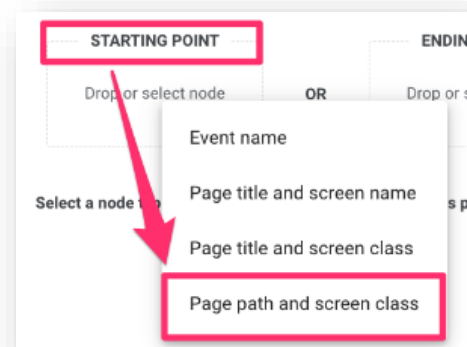
A couple more things to note are that the filter only allows for the use of “exactly matches” for dimensions and metrics, and only three metrics are available to be used as a value.



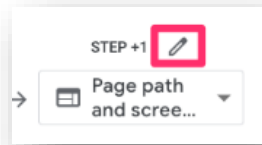
#3.8.1. Example #1: What do users do after landing on your site?

You may have created a funnel that follows the steps you assume users are taking when they land on your site, but the funnel has shown significant abandonment rates, so you want to figure out where users are actually going – this is where path exploration shines.

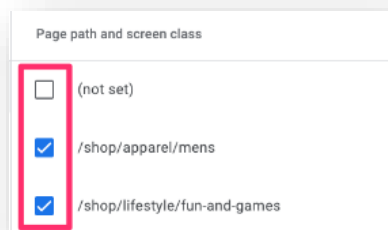
Click “Starting point”, select “Page path and screen class” and then find the page path that matches your site’s landing page. I find that the page title is not always the most reliable, so I prefer to use the page path.



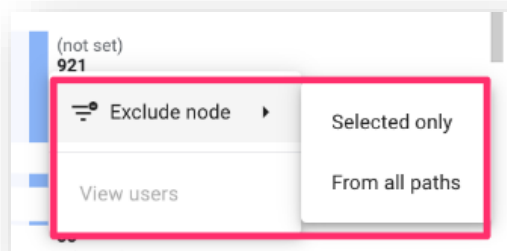
The data will begin to populate, and you may find that some (not set) page paths will appear. To remove any nodes you don't want to include in the path exploration, click the pencil icon at the top and unselect the page path.



Here, you can also select the values you want included in the path since GA4 will select the top five by default. You can do this for each node individually.

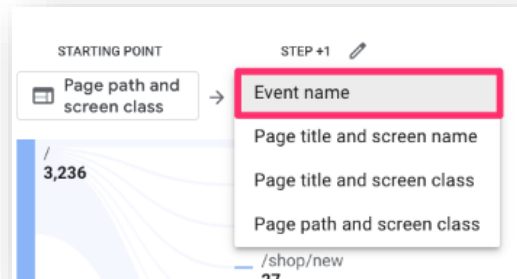


I prefer to remove the (not set) values since they don't provide any insightful information, making the report look cleaner. You can also right-click on the node you wish to exclude and choose whether to exclude it from all paths or just the one.



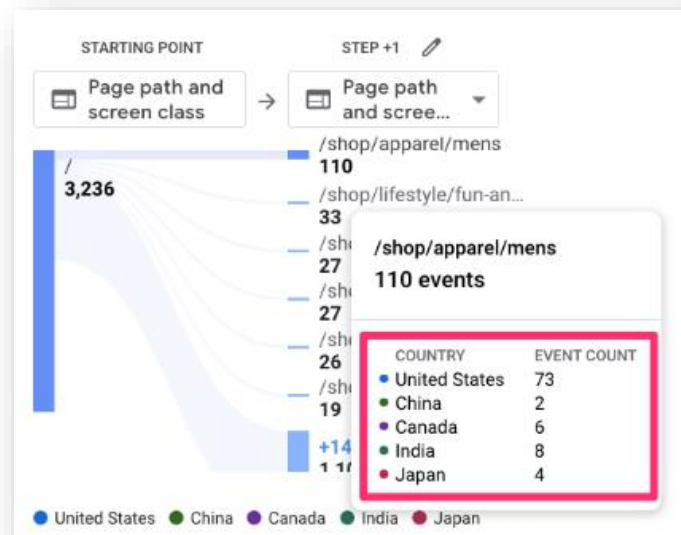
You can change the node type at any point. For example, if you decide to examine the action a user completes after landing on your site's homepage, you can change

the node type to “Event name.” You don’t need to stick to just one node type across the exploration!



Continue clicking on the nodes you are interested in to build the path. There can be up to 10 columns in the visualization.

Additionally, add a breakdown to the path exploration to go a little deeper into the data. For example, you can add “Country” as a dimension and then drag that into “Breakdown”. This will show you the event count for each node broken down by the top five countries.



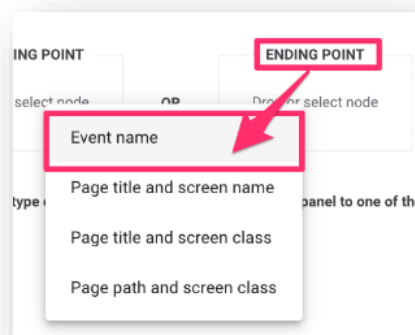
If you click on one of the values from the legend shown at the bottom, this will only highlight the path for that group.

#3.8.2. Example #2: What did users do before a purchase?

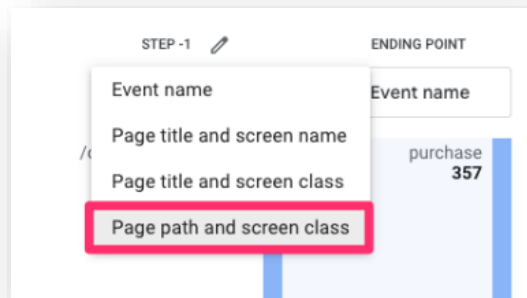
Alternatively, the path exploration allows you to provide an ending point, so you can see the steps leading up to an action like, let's say, a purchase. This type of report is helpful when you have unexpected results from a funnel exploration. You can plug in the final step of the funnel and see what users are *actually* doing before they reach this step.

This path exploration involves the use of e-commerce events, which requires additional configuration since these events are not automatically tracked by GA4. Learn more [here](#).

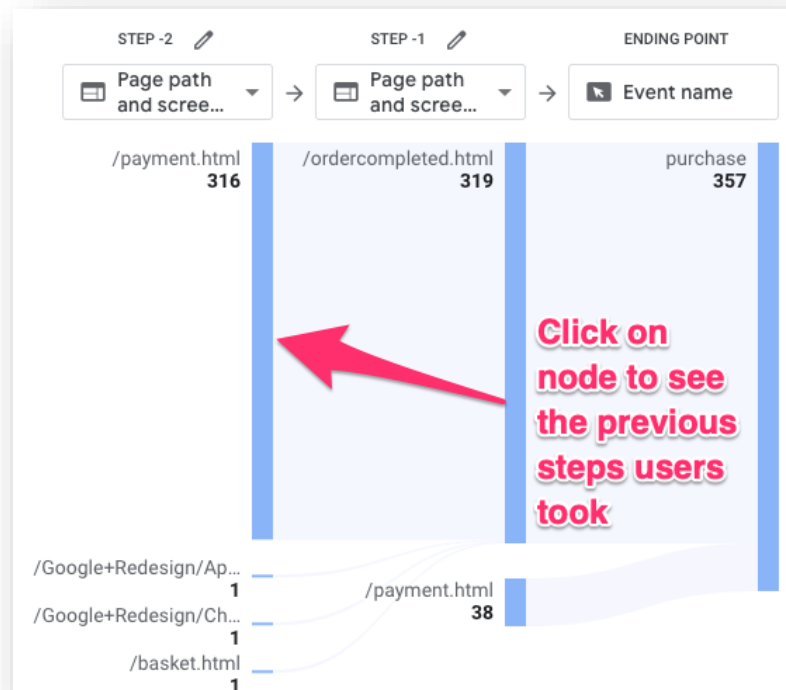
Click “Ending point”, select “Event name”, and then find the *purchase* event in the list.



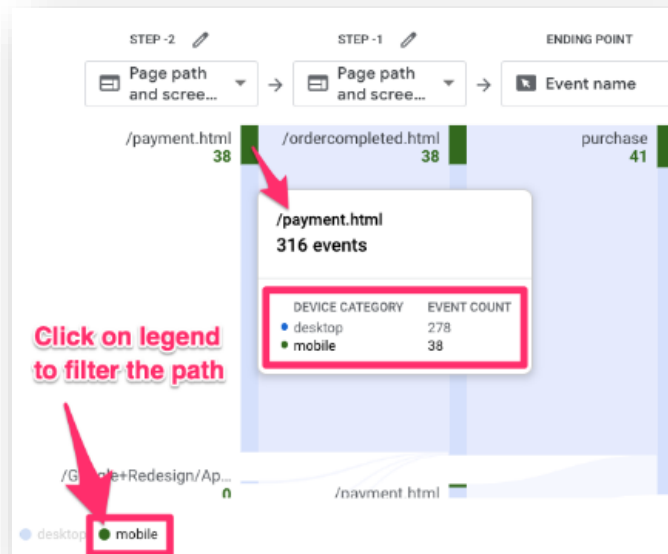
Data will now populate for the last and second last steps. You can select whether you want to see the previous steps as event names or page paths. I find that things can get a bit messy when you use the event name since there are a lot of auto-tracked events, like page views and clicks, that will appear, so I prefer to use the page path dimension.



You can choose to filter the nodes the same way as the previous example. Continue to click on the node that you want to explore further (up to 10 columns total).

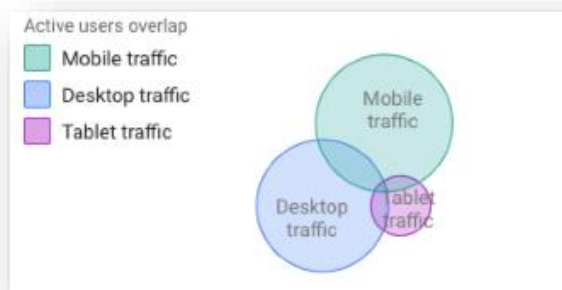


Add a breakdown by *Device category* to see the makeup of users for each step. You can click on a value in the bottom legen, like “mobile”, to filter the path to just users in that device category.



#3.9. Segment overlap

The segment overlap exploration in GA4 allows you to compare up to three user [segments](#) and identify commonalities and differences in behaviour between users in these segments. Essentially, it creates a Venn diagram to illustrate the connections between each group (while also providing the exact values for each section of the Venn diagram).

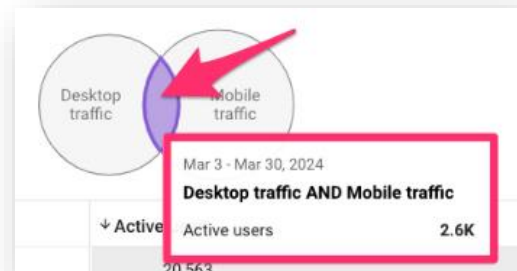


The one unique component in the Setting variable for segment overlap is **Breakdown**. As with the funnel and path explorations, this allows you to break down the report by a dimension of your choosing. However, you can have up to 500 rows for the dimension values in the segment overlap exploration.

[Read this article on segments in GA4](#) to learn more about the different types of segments and which one you should use. Do this before trying to create a segment overlap report.

#3.9.1. Example: Verify your user ID implementation

If you have implemented a user ID setup, then pull in the *Desktop traffic* and *Mobile traffic* segments from above (if you did the above example, then you have this already). As long as there is an overlap (however small it may be), this tells you that your setup is working properly!



If you don't have any overlap, it could be possible that you just don't have enough data yet (if you just implemented the user ID), or there is something wrong with the tracking. Review [this article on implementing user ID tracking](#), and if a developer helped you, talk with them about it.

The examples in this section—and most of the e-book—are simple but show the potential for uncovering some really interesting insights. Start simple, and then, naturally, you will begin to expand on your segments as you start to uncover different questions you want to answer.

#3.10. Cohort exploration

The cohort exploration in GA4 can help you get more insights into user retention. This technique will take all users (or just users that fit specific criteria) over a period and show you how many of them return to your site over the next few weeks or months. You can also specify conditions that need to be met for them to be included in the return cohort.

This may be easier to understand with an example. Using the image below, we can say that between March 5 and March 9, 9,810 users were in the initial cohort, and one week later, 590 fit the conditions to be included in the return cohort (6% of the initial group).

	WEEK 0	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3
All Users Active users	39,622	1,274	341	10
Mar 5 - Mar 9, 2024 9,810 users	9,810	590	323	9
Mar 10 - Mar 16, 2024 12,839 users	12,839			
Mar 17 - Mar 23, 2024 11,524 users	11,524			
Mar 24 - Mar 30, 2024 3,186 users	3,186			

Mar 5 - Mar 9, 2024 - Week 1

ACTIVE USERS

Sum of Active users

Active users per cohort user

590

6.01%

Some limitations to this report are that the data is based solely on the user's device data and will not include user ID (even if you collect it), and there is a maximum of 60 cohorts.

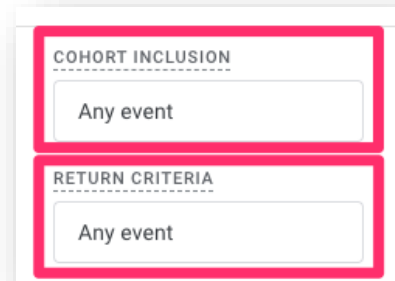
The unique components of the cohort exploration are:

- **Cohort inclusion:** The initial criteria a user must meet for the cohort.
- **Return criteria:** The condition a user needs to meet after completing the initial criteria to be included in the returning cohort columns.
- **Cohort granularity:** Specifies the time range of the cohort columns, e.g. daily (midnight to midnight of property time zone), weekly (Sunday to Saturday) or monthly (beginning to end of the month).
- **Calculation:** The methods for including users in the cohorts
 - *Standard* consists of all users who meet the return criteria for that period
 - *Rolling* includes only users who meet the return criteria for that period and all previous periods.
 - *Cumulative* includes users who meet the return criteria in *any* period.

#3.10.1. Example: Does a new feature improve user retention?

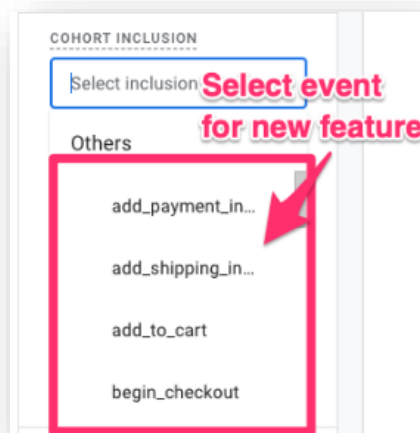
Let's say you make a big design of your site or launch a new feature at the start of the week. Cohort exploration will allow you to compare the retention of the users visiting your site that week with those who visited in the previous weeks to see if the change you made had a significant impact.

This cohort exploration is pretty simple. For the date range, select a few weeks before the change happened and at least a few weeks after the change happened. Set both the *Cohort inclusion* and *Return criteria* as "Any event".



A screenshot of a settings interface with two sections. The first section, titled "COHORT INCLUSION", contains a text input field with the value "Any event". The second section, titled "RETURN CRITERIA", also contains a text input field with the value "Any event". Both sections are highlighted with a red rectangular border.

If you're tracking the new feature with an event, you could also set the *Cohort inclusion* as this event. Then, you can see if the percentage of users returning to the site after interacting with the new feature is higher than in previous weeks.



A screenshot of a dropdown menu for "COHORT INCLUSION". The dropdown is open, showing a list of events. A red arrow points to the "add_payment_in..." option. A red text label "Select event for new feature" is positioned above the dropdown. The dropdown list is enclosed in a red rectangular border.

- add_payment_in...
- add_shipping_in...
- add_to_cart
- begin_checkout

Now, the cohort analysis will show you the number of users that completed any action (or the specific action you chose) in the *Week 0* column (these are the users included in the initial cohort) and then for each week after, the number (and percentage) of those users who returned to your site and completed any action.

	WEEK 0	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4
All Users	91,277	3,173		1,057	745
Active users					
Feb 4 - Feb 10, 2024 9,393 users	9,393	560	382	319	274
Feb 11 - Feb 17, 2024 11,012 users	11,012	642	390	318	282
Feb 18 - Feb 24, 2024 19,912 users	19,912			384	325
Feb 25 - Mar 2, 2024 12,943 users	12,943			327	15
Mar 3 - Mar 9, 2024 13,037 users	13,037			11	1

Hover to see details

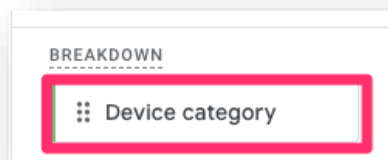
Feb 11 - Feb 17, 2024 • Week 1

ACTIVE USERS

Sum of Active users 642

Active users per cohort user 5.83%

To investigate further, you could add the *Device category* to the breakdown to see if there are any differences between devices.



For example, the retention rate for mobile users may be much lower than that for desktop users, indicating a bug in your mobile redesign.

	WEEK 0	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4
All Users	91,277	3,173	1,533	1,057	745
Active users					
Feb 4 - Feb 10, 2024 9,386 users	9,393	560	382	319	274
smart tv No users	0	0	0	0	0
tablet 219 users	219	8	7	7	2
mobile 3,456 users	3,456	79	46	29	21
desktop 5,711 users	5,711	473	329	283	251

#3.11. User lifetime

The User lifetime exploration in GA4 looks at the average values of some key metrics from the first time a user visited your site, broken down by various dimensions that mainly focus on the first-ever visit to your site, like the *First user medium* or *Last audience name*.

Last audience name	Total users	Lifetime transactions: Average	Lifetime engagement duration: Average	→ LTV: Average
Totals	41,003	0.11	6m 41s	\$15.48
1 Canada Purchasers	6	1.33	13m 12s	\$333.47
2 Purchasers	476	1.18	17m 37s	\$164.55
3 Predicted 28-day top spenders	1,091	0.31	19m 00s	\$41.48

There are some important things to note for these reports:

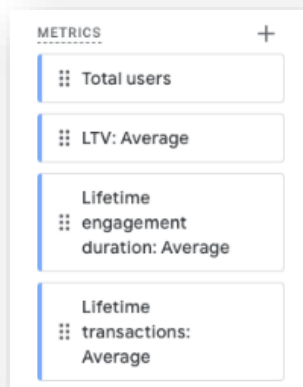
- Data is only available for users who have been active on your site after August 15, 2020, and there is a sampling limit of one million users for the free version of Google Analytics 4 and 10 million for GA4 360 properties.
- When you choose a date range, keep in mind that the entire lifetime of any users active in the date range will be included (so this includes activity before the date selected), and you can't change the end date (it's auto-set to yesterday).
- If a User ID is collected on your site, this will be used (more accurate data); otherwise, the client ID (for web) and app-instance ID (for app) will be used to identify users. Learn more about how to implement User ID for cross-device tracking [here](#).
- The only dimensions available are: *First user medium*, *First user source*, *First user campaign*, *Last audience name*, and *First visit date*.
- The only metrics available are: *Active users*, *Total users*, and all the *User lifetime* metrics.

#3.11.1. Example: Lifetime values by first medium

This isn't a report I use very often, but it is interesting to see if there are any noticeable differences in the lifetime metrics across different dimension values. In this case, we will see if there are any differences in metrics across the mediums users went through to land on your site for the first time.

One thing to note is that if you haven't implemented User ID tracking, then this won't be the most accurate report. Users who have cleared cookies or entered your site from a different browser (after their first visit) will now be counted again with – potentially – a different medium.

Once you have selected the “User lifetime” technique, the dimensions and metrics that can be used in the report will automatically load. You can still add some metrics, but the ones we need will already be available.



All you need to do is double-click on the *First user medium* under the dimensions, and the *Total users*, *Lifetime transactions: Average*, *Lifetime engagement duration: Average*, and *LTV: Average* (sum of revenue) for metrics.

First user medium	Total users	Lifetime transactions: Average	Lifetime engagement duration: Average	↓ LTV: Average
Totals	40,302	0.03	1m 54s	\$3.76
1 email	101	0.33	17m 41s	\$32.20
2 referral	665	0.05	3m 11s	\$4.33
3 (none)	32,654	0.03	1m 57s	\$3.92
4 organic	6,835	0.02	1m 14s	\$2.56
5 cpc	167	0.02	4m 45s	\$0.60
6 cpm	7	0	1.5s	\$0.00

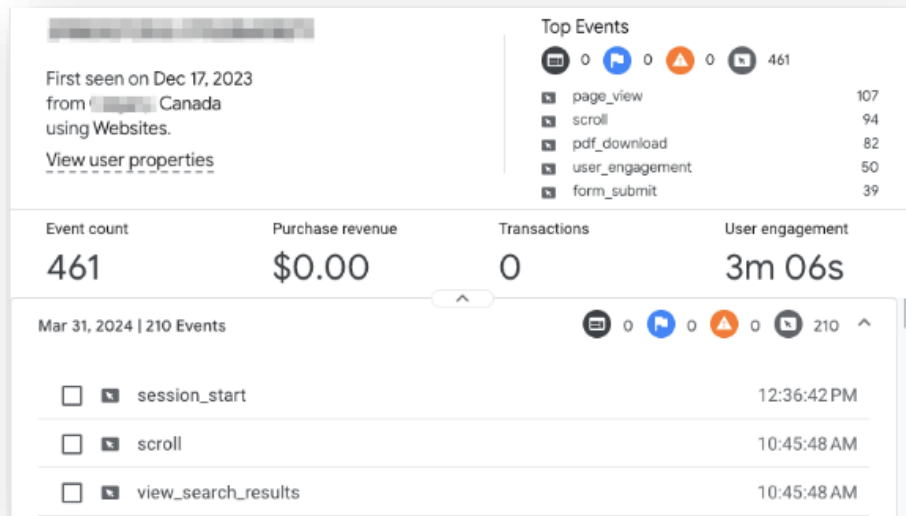
Click on one of the metric headers to sort the data in descending order to see the medium with the highest value for that metric.



The above results show that users who visited the site for the first time through email have the highest lifetime values, which is pretty neat!

#3.12. User explorer

The User explorer exploration in GA4 provides a detailed view of an individual user's interactions with your site. Again, this isn't a report that I use very often, but it will have its place in some people's analytics toolbox.



A unique component of this report is that there are only two available dimensions—effective user ID and stream name. The Effective user ID field will contain the *client ID*, *app instance ID*, or *User ID*. If you set your reporting identity to “By device only,” the User ID will not be displayed in this dimension (even if you are tracking it).

ROWS	
Effective user ID	
Stream name	

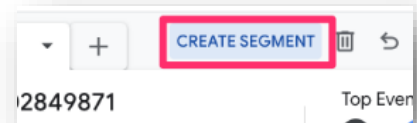
However, the metrics are less limited, and you can still capture quite a bit of information on the user.

So, how can you use this technique? You can click on an individual in the table to examine their actions across multiple sessions.

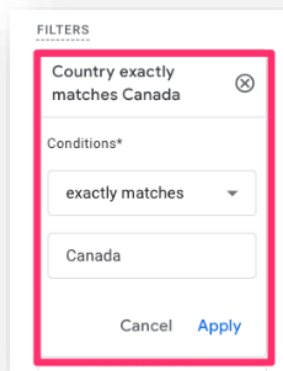
Effective user ID	Stream name	↓ Event count	Sessions	Views
Totals		461	11	107
1	Websites	461	11	107

Click on the ID to see the user's activity

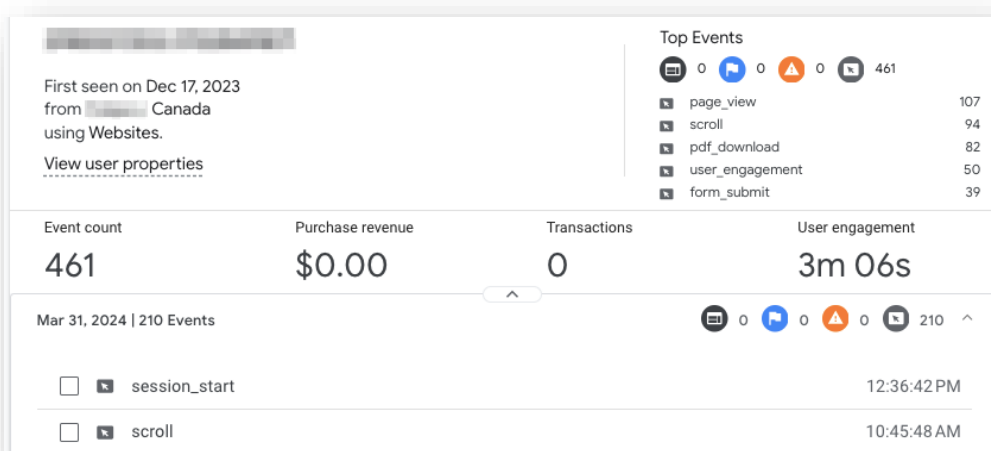
This report may be helpful for building out segments if you have specific patterns in individuals and want to explore them on a larger scale. Select the events you wish to include in a segment and click “Create segment”.



You can also use a filter to explore a user who has completed a specific action or lives in a particular location and see granular insights into user behaviour and preferences.



An individual user’s view (profile) is fairly limited (compared to what we had in UA). For example, it doesn’t show the URL for where an event happened.



Regardless, it may be worth clicking through a few individuals just to see if anything stands out. Let me know in the comments if there is a unique way that you use this report!

Final words

While this book has provided a detailed walkthrough of the reports available in Google Analytics 4 — from standard reports to more advanced explorations — it's important to recognize that we've only scratched the surface.

Understanding the GA4 interface and becoming familiar with its various reporting tools is certainly valuable, but reports themselves are never the essence of analytics. The real power of analytics lies in the ability to ask the **right questions** and know what truly matters for your business.

Data is only as useful as the questions it helps answer. A report can show you hundreds of metrics, but unless you know what's relevant for your business goals, it's easy to get lost in the noise. That's why it's crucial to start with a clear understanding of what needs to be measured, which KPIs will drive business outcomes, and what insights can help make better decisions.

This book has been about helping you get comfortable with GA4's tools, but in my Google Analytics 4 course, we dive much deeper into the strategic side of analytics. There we'd focus on identifying the right metrics, understanding business objectives, and learning how to ask the right questions that ultimately drive success. Only then can you effectively use the reporting tools in GA4 to find the answers that matter.

As you continue your analytics journey, always remember that reports are just a means to an end. What truly matters is the ability to translate data into insights that can help your business grow. By mastering this mindset, you'll unlock the real potential of Google Analytics 4 — and of data itself.

How to properly learn Google Analytics 4

Some people try to learn Google Analytics 4 by themselves. They read the documentation and do a lot by trial and error. In the end, they will waste a lot of time. And time is money.

Others might try to enroll in a GA4 course and learn there. But, the problem with many GA courses is that they focus just on GA features. They forget the most important things:

- How to collect **meaningful** data
- How to get **insights** from that data

That is the problem that I solve with my [Google Analytics 4 course](#):

- It will help you **save a lot of time**
- It will also teach you how to properly **plan your setup**
- You will learn how to **configure GA4** the right way
- You will know **what is important to track**
- You will learn how to **get insights** from your data

Since 2016, I have taught many marketers and analysts to get the most out of Google Tag Manager and Google Analytics.

If you want to become a GA4 power user and benefit from it, check out my [Google Analytics 4 course](#).

This course includes:

- 11 Modules
- Time-saving checklists, templates, etc.
- Practical tasks and a sandbox website to practice
- Lifetime 24/7 access to the course material
- Free updates
- Complete hand-holding and support
- And so much more!

[Learn more about this course](#)



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